

The Harmonies of Hope

Volume One

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C.D. Howell

For every child who ever found God between the block and the
blessing.
And for every brother who stayed close enough to hear the music.

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The Harmonies of Hope, Volume One

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This is a work of creative nonfiction.

Names and identifying details of some individuals have been
changed to protect their privacy.

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About the Author

The Two-Family Flat

There are certain places that hold memories like a jar holds fireflies, illuminating them with a soft, pulsing glow whenever you dare to peek inside. For me, that place was a two-family flat on the east side of Detroit, a brick testament to resilience that stood on a block where the houses leaned like tired soldiers, shoulders slumped from decades of watching the world turn. Each porch, a slight tilt to its posture, each windowpane a misty eye reflecting the often-grey Michigan sky. They weren't broken, these houses, not really. Just weathered, worn in all the right places, like a favorite pair of shoes that had seen better days but still carried you wherever you needed to go. And within the walls of our flat, there was more love than the aged plaster and peeling paint could ever hope to contain, a love so profound it seemed to seep into the very foundations, making the whole structure hum with a quiet, enduring strength.

The bottom floor, a sanctuary of scent and sound, belonged to Grandma Lois. Her kitchen was a constant summer, a pocket of perpetual warmth that defied Detroit's harsh winters, not just from the gas stove that always seemed to be simmering something savory, but from the sheer, gravitational weight of her presence. She was a woman woven from starlight and stubbornness, her skin the color of deep riverbed clay, her hands scarred with the stories of a thousand meals, a thousand lives nurtured. She hummed hymns while she cooked, old ones that coiled around your heart like a familiar embrace, the kind that don't have names anymore, just melodies passed down through generations of Black women who understood, deep in their bones, that some prayers are best sung over a pot of greens. It was a wordless conversation with the Most High, a language understood universally by those whose faith had been forged in the fires of hardship and hope. The scent of collard greens, slow-cooked with smoked turkey necks and a whisper of vinegar, was the unofficial fragrance of our home, a comforting shroud that clung to the curtains, permeated the furniture, and settled into the very fabric of our clothes, a constant, delicious reminder of where we came from and who we were. It was the smell of Sunday, even on a Tuesday, the smell of grace, every single day.

I sat at the kitchen table, a small, eight-year-old in a world that felt impossibly large, my feet dangling above the worn linoleum that bore the faint, ghost-like patterns of countless spills and hurried footsteps. The radio, a sturdy, cream-colored Zenith, was always on, a steady stream of Motown gold pouring from its modest speaker. Always Motown. It was the soundtrack to our lives, the pulsing heartbeat of our city. On this particular afternoon, The Temptations were crooning "My Girl," their voices a perfect blend of sweetness and swagger, and I felt the music deep in my chest, a quiet vibration that resonated with something I couldn't quite grasp. In the next room, the soft, rhythmic hiss of steam filled the air as my mother, a woman who could wrestle a demon into submission with one hand and iron a crisp pleat with the other, worked diligently on a pile of clothes. The sharp, clean scent of heated fabric and spray starch mingled with Grandma Lois's cooking, creating a unique olfactory tapestry that was distinctly home.

"Chris, baby," my mother's voice drifted in, clear and unyielding, yet laced with the tenderness that only a mother can perfect, "go tell your brother to come eat before this food gets cold and I give it to the Lord." Her implication was clear: waste not, want not, and certainly, disrespect not the blessing of a hot meal. But I didn't move. My small body remained stubbornly still on the hard kitchen chair, my gaze fixed on the steam rising from a pot on the stove, watching it twist and disappear, only to reappear again. I was listening. Not truly to my grandmother's humming, though its comforting drone was a constant. Not merely to the soaring harmonies of the Temptations, though their melody was undeniably captivating. I was listening to something underneath both, something deeper, more fundamental. It was a rhythm I couldn't name yet, a frequency that hummed between the music and the silence, between the gritty realities of the block outside and the sanctified blessing of the food simmering inside. It was the pulse of everything, the unspoken language that connected us all. It was the whisper of God in the everyday.

Our two-family flat sat on a street that had, undoubtedly, seen better decades. The vibrant greens and blues of freshly painted porches had long faded, now peeling from the wood like sunburned skin after a long, forgotten summer. The sidewalks were cracked in places, miniature canyons for rainwater, and the occasional rogue dandelion pushed its way through the concrete, a defiant burst of yellow in a world of grey. Driveways held cars that seemed to run on faith and starter fluid more than gasoline, their rusted bodies telling tales of countless repairs, of makeshift solutions and stubborn determination. Mr. Henderson's '78 Caprice, permanently parked at the curb, its hood perpetually up, was practically a neighborhood landmark, a monument to the eternal hope of one more start. But inside the flat, life pulsed with a warmth that no winter could freeze and no hardship could dim. It was a warmth born of laughter, of shared burdens, of the unwavering belief that tomorrow held the promise of something better, even if today was just another struggle. It was a warmth that permeated every corner, every crack, every creak of the old house, making it a living, breathing entity, a haven in a sometimes-harsh world.

Upstairs, that's where my immediate family resided — all seven of us, packed into three bedrooms and a single bathroom that required a schedule posted prominently on the door, meticulously handwritten by my mother, outlining precise times for showers and mirror access. It was a system that, more often than not, dissolved into good-natured chaos and urgent pleas, but it was our chaos. My mother, a force of nature built from equal parts prayer and iron will, ran the household like a well-oiled machine, her voice a finely tuned instrument that could comfort a crying baby with a lullaby-soft whisper and correct a grown man with a single, sharp syllable, all in the same breath. She was the anchor, the strategist, the unwavering moral compass. My father, a man whose hands were rough from working two jobs — one at the Ford plant, the other driving a jitney on weekends — still found time to sit at the head of the dinner table every evening. His tired eyes would soften as he looked at each of us, his calloused fingers tracing invisible patterns on the tablecloth, his words always soft, always measured, always kind.

"How was school today?" he would ask, his gaze gentle yet probing, looking each child directly in the eye, one by one, as if their answers were the most important news in the world, more critical than any headline in the Detroit Free Press. He didn't just ask; he listened. He listened for the unspoken, for the hesitations, for the subtle shifts in tone. Darius might offer a concise "Fine, Daddy," already too cool for elaborate explanations. Tamika, ever the dramatist, might launch into a detailed recounting of a playground injustice. When it came to me and Mike, we often just exchanged a glance, a silent agreement to keep our own counsel, though sometimes, a particularly exciting story about recess or a new book would tumble out of one of us, and the other would nod vigorously in agreement, adding details as if we shared a single memory bank. That dinner table, worn and scarred like everything else in our home, was more than just a place to eat; it was a daily communion, a grounding ritual that reaffirmed our connection, our shared identity as the Howell family. It was where we learned to speak, and more importantly, to listen, to each other.

I was the middle child — not the oldest, who carried the burgeoning weight of responsibility and the unspoken expectations of setting an example; and not the youngest, who carried the luxury of being babied, of existing in a perpetual state of adoration. My position afforded me a unique vantage point. I was the one who watched. The one who listened, truly listened. The one who noticed things that other people walked right past, too busy or too preoccupied to catch the subtle shifts, the quiet truths. It was a comfortable place to be, a hidden corner from which to observe the intricate dance of family life.

Like the way my mother's voice changed when she prayed at night, after the house had finally settled into its nighttime creaks and groans. It became softer, more broken, almost fractured, as if she were handing something incredibly heavy, something she could no longer carry alone, to someone she trusted completely, someone unseen but profoundly felt. I'd sometimes hear her from my bed, the low murmur of her supplications drifting through the thin walls, not a performance, but a raw, honest conversation with her Creator, punctuated by sighs that sounded like the letting go of burdens. Like the way the streetlights on our block flickered in a pattern that sounded, if you listened carefully enough in the dead of night, almost like a drumbeat, a syncopated rhythm that spoke of the city's tireless pulse, even when it slept. A subtle thrum-thrum-thump, a light going out, then another, then a different one coming back on, a silent symphony of electrical currents and urban life. And like the way music seemed to live inside the very walls of our home, not just coming from the radio or the record player, but permeating the plaster and wood, the way electricity lived inside the wires — invisible, essential, always humming, a deep, resonant vibration that was as much a part of the house as the air we breathed. It was the soul of the flat, a constant melody that underscored every joy, every sorrow, every quiet moment.

There were five siblings in all. The oldest, Darius, was fifteen and carried himself with a quiet authority that belied his years. He was already talking about getting a job, about saving for his own car, about the future that stretched before him like an open road. He moved with a deliberate grace, his eyes often thoughtful, observing much like I did, but with a different kind of focus, a nascent sense of responsibility already weighing on his young shoulders. He wasn't one for loud pronouncements, but when he spoke, we listened, knowing his words were considered. Next came Tamika, thirteen, a whirlwind of vibrant energy. She had our mother's fiery spirit and our father's stubborn streak — a combination that made her both the most loved and the most argued-with person in the house. Her laughter could fill a room, her indignation could ignite a storm, and her loyalty was fierce. She was always braiding someone's hair, or humming the latest R&B hit, or staging a dramatic monologue for anyone who would listen. Then there was me, Chris, at eight years old, navigating my observations. After me came my brother, Mike, just one year younger, and between the two of us there was a bond that everyone in the neighborhood could see but no one could fully explain.

We weren't just brothers. We were ¹⁴echoes of each other, two halves of a whole, intrinsically linked. Where I went, Mike followed, a loyal shadow. Where Mike laughed, I was already smiling, catching the contagion of his joy. We shared a bedroom, a small space crammed with bunk beds that groaned under our combined weight, and a dresser whose drawers were perpetually overflowing with clothes that almost fit us both, hand-me-downs from Darius or sometimes just clothes that had mysteriously migrated from one side of the room to the other. We shared secrets whispered under blankets after the lights went out, illuminated by the illicit glow of a stolen flashlight, stories of playground triumphs and classroom embarrassments, dreams that felt too big to speak of in daylight. Teachers at school often mixed up our names, even though I had a small scar above my left eyebrow from a childhood tumble, and Mike had a mischievous glint in his eyes that I lacked. Neighbors, seeing us always together, called us "the twins" even though we weren't. Our mother, in moments of exasperation or hurried affection, sometimes just pointed at both of us and said "you two" because separating us felt unnatural, like trying to pull apart a song from its melody, like trying to distinguish the rhythm from the beat. We were a single unit, a two-man band navigating the world side by side.

And the youngest was baby Keisha, still in diapers, still the undisputed center of everyone's affection, a tiny monarch ruling our hearts with her gummy smiles and uninhibited giggles. She was blissfully unaware that the world outside our front door was not always as warm, as safe, as utterly devoted as the one inside. She knew only the gentle hands that held her, the soft voices that cooed her name, the constant presence of love that surrounded her like a protective aura. Her cries could halt any argument, her laughter could melt any tension, and her small, trusting presence was a constant reminder of the purity and hope we all clung to.

But my world, and Mike's, and Darius's, and Tamika's, and Keisha's, extended far beyond the seven people who lived upstairs. It stretched down the creaky wooden stairs to Grandma Lois's kitchen, and from there, it reached out to encompass the entire block, the whole vibrant tapestry of our community.

On any given evening — and especially on weekends, when the very air seemed to crackle with anticipation — the flat would fill with family in ways that defied the laws of square footage and conventional physics. It was as if the walls themselves breathed, expanding to accommodate the influx of love and laughter. Aunties would arrive, their arms laden with foil-covered pans emitting tantalizing aromas of macaroni and cheese, candied yams, or peach cobbler still warm from their own ovens. Each woman, a matriarch in her own right, would greet Grandma Lois with a hug and a familiar phrase, their voices a symphony of affection and shared history. Uncles would follow, their deep voices rumbling with stories from the week, their hands ready for a game of dominoes that would inevitably get loud, the clack-clack-clack of the tiles against the kitchen table a comforting percussive backdrop to the evening. And then came the cousins, a joyful stampede of energy that could power a city block, their excited chatter and boundless enthusiasm instantly transforming the relatively quiet house into a bustling hub of activity. Their arrival was like a dam breaking, a joyous flood of youthful exuberance.

"Y'all go on in the back," the adults would say, their voices a chorus of gentle but firm authority, waving the children toward the bedrooms like a seasoned crossing guard directing traffic. It wasn't a suggestion; it was a directive, an unspoken but universally understood command. And the children obeyed — not because we necessarily wanted to, for the lure of adult conversations and the possibility of a stray piece of fried chicken was strong, but because respect was not optional in a Black household in Detroit in the 1990s. Respect was the very air you breathed, the foundational pillar upon which all other interactions rested. You said "yes ma'am" and "no sir" with conviction, not just politeness. You did not talk back, not unless you wanted to feel the swift, stinging justice of a mother's open hand or a father's stern glare. And you absolutely, under no circumstances, interrupted grown folks when they were talking, especially when they were discussing matters of consequence, or simply enjoying the rare luxury of uninterrupted conversation. It was a lesson learned early, absorbed through observation and occasional, swift correction, a vital part of our cultural education, teaching us our place in the intricate hierarchy of family and community.

But what happened in the back rooms, once the door clicked shut and the muffled sounds of adult conviviality receded, was its own kind of magic. It was a world within a world, a secret society of youth.

The cousins would pile into the bedrooms — eight, ten, sometimes twelve deep, a writhing, giggling mass of limbs and laughter. We'd sprawl across the bunk beds, commandeer the floor space, and even squeeze onto the small, upholstered chair in the corner. And then the games would begin, fueled by the sheer kinetic energy of so many young souls confined to a relatively small space. Monopoly marathons that lasted three hours and inevitably ended in accusations of cheating, often hurled with dramatic flair by someone who had just landed on Boardwalk with a hotel. "You moved my piece!" "No, I didn't! You always try to cheat when you losing!" The plastic houses and hotels would scatter, the paper money would fly, and the indignant cries would escalate until an older cousin, or Darius, would intervene, restoring a semblance of order. Wrestling matches would break out on the floor, a tangle of arms and legs, until someone hit the wall too hard with a dull thud, and an uncle's voice, booming and unmistakable even through the closed door, would cut through the joyous din from the living room: "Y'all better not break nothing in there! I hear that wall, I'm comin' in there with my belt!" The threat, though rarely executed, was always enough to bring a temporary, chastened quiet.

Sometimes we played hide-and-seek in a space far too small to genuinely hide in, which only made it funnier. We'd cram ourselves behind the bedroom door, or under a pile of laundry, or beneath a bed, our stifled giggles giving us away almost immediately, leading to joyous shouts of "Found you!" and another frenzied dash to the designated "home base." Sometimes we told ghost stories under a blanket tent, fashioned from every spare sheet and blanket we could find, the air thick with dramatic whispers and exaggerated gasps, while someone held a flashlight under their chin, casting ghoulis shadows on their face. The tales were always the same, passed down from older cousins, but the thrill of telling them in the dark, surrounded by our tribe, never diminished. Sometimes, though, after the initial burst of energy had subsided and the games had wound down, we just lay on the floor, side by side, staring at the ceiling or the dusty baseboards, and talked — about school, about crushes on classmates, about the unfairness of parents, about what we wanted to be when we grew up, our voices softer now, more reflective.

"I'm gonna be a fireman," one cousin, Jamal, would declare with unwavering certainty, his chest puffed out slightly, imagining himself heroically saving lives. "I'm gonna drive one of them big red trucks, sirens wailing."

"Pssh, I'm gonna play in the NBA," said another, Kevin, already taller than most of us, bouncing an imaginary basketball in his hands, his eyes alight with the dream of slam dunks and roaring crowds. "Get a big contract, buy my mama a house."

"I'm gonna be rich," said a third, Tanya, with the absolute, unshakeable confidence of someone who had never seen a bank statement, let alone balanced a checkbook. "Own my own store, sell everything." Her declaration was met with a chorus of "oohs" and "aahs," the concept of boundless wealth a magical,

distant land.

I didn't always answer when it was my turn. My role, even then, was often that of the quiet observer. I'd lie on my back, a small knot of cousins around me, staring at the slightly water-stained popcorn ceiling, tracing the patterns with my eyes. I was listening, as always, to the muffled sounds of the adults in the other room — the resonant bass of an uncle's laughter, the soulful wail of a Motown ballad filtering through the floorboards, the clink of glasses as someone refilled their sweet tea, the rhythmic cadence of conversation that rose and fell like waves on a distant shore. It was a symphony of life, rich and complex, and I absorbed it all, letting it wash over me. And in those quiet moments, a profound truth would settle in my young heart, a knowing that transcended words. I'd think: This is what home sounds like. It wasn't just the specific noises, but the feeling they evoked: security, belonging, an unbreakable connection. It was the sound of love made audible.

One by one, as the evening deepened and the sugar highs wore off, the cousins would fall asleep wherever they landed. On beds, sprawled across the floor amidst discarded comic books and board game pieces, curled up on piles of coats that had been tossed into corners, their small bodies finally succumbing to the exhaustion of so much living. The room would grow quieter, filled only with the soft sounds of youthful breathing. Later, much later, the adults would peek in, their faces softened by the evening's fellowship, illuminated by the dim light from the hallway. They'd shake their heads with a gentle smile, a mixture of exasperation and profound tenderness in their eyes, and then, with an almost reverential quietness, they'd close the door softly, leaving us in our shared slumber.

Those nights, those crowded, boisterous, ultimately peaceful nights, bonded the cousins in ways that regular family ties couldn't fully explain. We became more than just relatives, more than names on a family tree. We became a tribe, a collective consciousness forged in the crucible of shared space and shared dreams. We were connected by blood, yes, by the undeniable threads of lineage, but also, and perhaps more profoundly, by the shared memory of being small together, of being safe together, of falling asleep to the constant, comforting sound of love resonating from the next room, knowing, without a doubt, that we were exactly where we were supposed to be. It was the genesis of my own harmony, the first note in a lifelong song of hope.

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The Brothers

There are some bonds that the world just can't quite explain. They ain't born of blood alone, or shared history, though both certainly play their part. No, some bonds feel like they were etched into your very spirit before you even took your first breath, a divine blueprint laid out just for you. Among all my siblings – and Lord knows, in a house full of us, there was always plenty of love and plenty of noise – I shared something with my brother that went deeper than proximity, deeper than the everyday hum of family life. It was deeper than the shared meals at the kitchen table, heaped high with collard greens and fried chicken every Sunday, our elbows knocking, our laughter echoing off the linoleum. Deeper than the twin beds pushed close together in our cramped room, where the whispers of night-time secrets felt like prayers. Deeper even than the collective sigh of resignation, or the stinging slap to the back of the legs, when one of us broke Mama's favorite porcelain bird and neither would confess, meaning both of us caught the wrath.

What we shared was a frequency,^{2,3} a wavelength tuned so precisely it was like we were two halves of the same cosmic radio signal. A way of being in the world that vibrated at the exact same pitch, a silent melody only we could hear. Looking back, I see it clear as a Detroit summer sky – we were always just on with each other.

My brother, Michael, was only a year younger than me, but most folks, strangers and family alike, often thought we were twins. We were the same height for the longest time, both of us shooting up like beanpoles. We had the same easy, slightly loping walk, a rhythm learned from navigating cracked sidewalks and dodging potholes on the east side. We'd laugh at the exact same moment, sometimes at something only we saw, a shared glance igniting a silent explosion of mirth that left others scratching their heads. When one of us started a sentence, the other could finish it, not just with the right words, but with the exact inflection, the very spirit of what the other meant to say. And if one of us got hurt, a scraped knee from a bike spill or a sting from a stray wasp, the other would flinch, a phantom pain mirroring the real one. It was uncanny, almost spooky to some. Our Auntie Mae, a woman whose wisdom was as deep as her Sunday morning gravy, used to just shake her head and chuckle, her gold earrings shimmering. "Y'all two," she'd say, a slow smile spreading across her face as she watched us chase each other through her meticulously kept rose bushes, "Y'all like one person in two bodies. Lord have mercy, what God done made there." Her voice, a rich alto seasoned with years of church solos, always held a note of wonder when she spoke of us. It wasn't just the physical resemblance, you see, it was the way our spirits seemed to intertwine, a double helix of brotherhood.

Our mother, bless her eternal heart,²⁴ she understood it in her own way, a way steeped in faith and the profound mysteries of creation. She'd gather us close, one arm around each of our skinny shoulders, her breath smelling of fried dough and the vanilla extract she always kept on the counter. Her voice would soften, losing its usual no-nonsense edge. "God made y'all close for a reason," she'd tell us, looking from one earnest face to the other, her eyes deep pools of love and warning. "Don't you ever let the world pull you apart. Not for money, not for pride, not for no man or woman. You hear me?" We heard her. We always did. It was more than a maternal instruction; it was a sacred charge, a prophecy whispered into the tender ears of two boys who didn't yet understand the full weight of her words, but felt their truth in their bones.

Every morning, bright or gray, summer or snow-dusted, we walked to school together. Our path was the familiar stretch of Kercheval Avenue, past the faded brick of two-family flats, past Mrs. Henderson's prize-winning petunias, past the corner store with its perpetually sticky floor and the scent of stale chips and grape soda. It wasn't a formal march, no side-by-side military precision. Ours was a loose, gravitational orbit, a dance of casual companionship perfected over years. Sometimes one of us would be slightly ahead, kicking at a loose pebble, his worn sneakers scuffing the pavement. Then the other would surge forward, catching up, a shoulder bumping playfully against a shoulder. We'd walk in unison for a spell, then one would lag behind, drawn by the glint of a discarded bottle cap, or the irresistible urge to kick a crumpled soda can down the block, making it clatter and skip like a metallic drum. The sounds of the morning street were our soundtrack: the distant rumble of a D-DOT bus, the cheerful shout of Mr. Johnson watering his lawn, the ever-present thrum of Motown radio leaking from open windows –

Marvin Gaye's plaintive wail, Stevie Wonder's joyful exuberance, the Temptations harmonizing like angels.

We didn't always talk. We didn't need to. The silence between us was its own kind of conversation, a comfortable, knowing space where thoughts and feelings were exchanged without a single word. A glance, a shared smirk, a nudge – that was our language, rich and full. We knew what the other was thinking, what joke was about to land, what mischief was brewing.

At school, we were known. Not for being troublemakers, though Lord knows we had our moments, particularly if a teacher dared to separate us for too long. No, we were known for being inseparable. “The Brothers,” they called us, not just the teachers but the other kids too. It was a title, a badge of honor. If a teacher, exasperated by some shared whispering or a synchronized giggle, sent one of us to the office, the other would mysteriously appear five minutes later. “Excuse me, Ms. Jenkins,” Michael would say, his eyes wide and innocent, “I gotta use the bathroom. Real bad.” Or I’d show up, claiming I forgot my lunch money and had to tell him. It was a flimsy excuse, but the teachers, even as they sighed, often let it slide. They’d seen it enough to know it was futile to fight. If one of us got into an argument on the playground – usually over who got next on the basketball court or a perceived slight during dodgeball – the other materialized at his side before the first fist was even raised. Our presence alone, the silent, unwavering solidarity, was often enough to de-escalate the situation. Kids knew. They knew. People joked about it, of course. Big kids, little kids, even the lunch lady with her hairnet and her knowing smile. “If you got a problem with one of them,” they’d say, a twinkle in their eye, “you got a problem with both of them. Best just leave ‘em alone.” It was funny because it was true. And in a neighborhood where protection sometimes meant strength in numbers, that truth was a comfort, a silent promise.

But the real bond – the deep, resonant chord that would shape both of our lives, give us purpose, and anchor us through the coming storms – that bond was music. It was more than a shared interest; it was a shared language, a spiritual conduit that flowed between us, connecting us to something ancient and profound.

It started at home, not with us, but with our older siblings. Our house, a two-story flat on the east side, was always alive with sound. The smell of Mama's cooking – onions caramelizing, spices blooming – often mingled with the cacophony of amateur musicianship. Darius, our eldest brother, had a keyboard that lived in the corner of the living room, draped with a crocheted doily when not in use. He played with the kind of casual, effortless skill that suggested he could be truly great if he ever decided to take it seriously. His fingers would dance across the keys, coaxing out gospel hymns one minute, then a smooth jazz riff the next, his head tilted, his eyes half-closed in concentration. Sometimes he'd play those deep, soulful Motown bass lines, making the floorboards hum beneath our feet. Tamika, our older sister, had a flute, a gleaming silver bird that she practiced in the bathroom. "The acoustics are better in here," she'd claim, her voice echoing slightly, though everyone suspected she just wanted privacy, away from the boisterous energy of the younger ones. Her practice sessions were like delicate birdsong, sometimes hesitant, sometimes soaring, the high, clear notes piercing through the everyday din of the house.

Michael and I, we were the perpetual audience. We'd sit in the hallway, cross-legged on the worn carpet, listening, our ears straining to catch every nuance. We'd press our ears against the closed bathroom door, the cool wood vibrating with Tamika's scales. We'd stand in the living room doorway, mesmerized by Darius's nimble fingers, trying to memorize the patterns, the way his body swayed with the rhythm. We'd tap rhythms on our legs, a silent drumming accompaniment to whatever melody filled the air. We'd tap on tables, on the backs of chairs, on walls, on anything that vibrated, anything that could make a sound. Our hands were restless, our minds alive with the urge to create.

I remember one afternoon, Mama found us in the kitchen. We'd pulled out every pot and pan she owned – the big cast-iron skillet, the dented aluminum saucepans, the stainless steel mixing bowls – and had them upturned on the linoleum floor. We were beating on them with wooden spoons and drumsticks we'd fashioned from fallen tree branches, a wild, percussive symphony of clatter and clang. The kitchen was a glorious mess, a metallic jungle gym of sound. I braced myself for the scolding, for the familiar “Y'all gon' scratch up my good pots!” But instead, Mama just stood in the doorway, framed by the late afternoon sun spilling through the window, and a slow, soft smile spread across her face. Her hands, usually busy, were clasped in front of her apron.

“Lord,” she said quietly, almost a whisper, her eyes shining with something I couldn't quite name then, but recognize now as a deep sense of pride and understanding. “These boys got music in their blood.” She wasn't mad. She wasn't even surprised. It was as if she'd seen it coming, a prophecy unfolding right there in her kitchen.

She was right. But she didn't know²⁸ yet how deep it ran, how it would become the very current that propelled us, the language that articulated our unspoken hopes and fears, the spiritual anchor that held us fast when the world tried to pull us adrift. We were just two boys making joyful noise, but in Mama's eyes, she saw the seeds of something more. She saw the legacy. She saw the future.

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The turning point came when I was in fourth grade. It was a crisp autumn day, the kind where the air smelled like burning leaves and distant possibility. Our school, Marcus Garvey Elementary, announced that they were introducing a concert band program. I remember the buzz that went through the school, a ripple of excitement and curiosity. A man in a brown suit, Mr. Coleman, the new band teacher, came to the auditorium for an assembly. He wasn't a flashy man, but his presence filled the room with a quiet authority. He laid out instruments on a long table at the front of the stage, gleaming under the harsh fluorescent lights like a buffet of possibility, a feast for the senses. Trumpets, polished to a blinding sheen, caught the light and seemed to sing even in their stillness. Clarinets lay nestled in their velvet-lined cases, dark wood and silver keys, looking like sleeping, elegant animals. Flutes glittered like silver arrows. And in the corner, almost shy, sat a tuba, large and magnificent, a brass throne waiting for its king. The air itself seemed to hum with the unspoken promise of sound.

I walked along the table slowly, my heart thumping a strange rhythm against my ribs, my eyes wide with wonder. It smelled of brass cleaner, of oiled wood, of something new and exciting. My fingers hovered over each instrument, longing to touch, to explore, but not quite daring. Each one called to me, a silent invitation. The trumpet's sharp angles, the saxophone's seductive curve, the drum's taut skin. But then I stopped.

I stopped in front of the trombone.

It was long and golden, a magnificent, awkward beast. It wasn't sleek like a flute or compact like a clarinet. It had this long, slender slide instead of keys, which meant you didn't just press buttons to find the notes. You had to feel them, to stretch out and pull back, to intuit the exact space in the air where a sound was born. It required breath, a deep, foundational breath that started in your belly and resonated through your chest. It required precision, to hit that sweet spot in the slide, but more than that, it required something that I would later learn to call soul. It looked like hard work, like a challenge. And for some reason, that's what drew me in.

I reached out, my hand trembling slightly, and picked it up. It was heavier than I expected, a solid weight of brass and purpose. The cold metal felt alive in my hands.

Mr. Coleman, a kind-faced man with spectacles perched on his nose, had been watching me, his gaze perceptive. He walked over, his brown suit rustling softly. "That one's hard, son," he said, his voice gentle but firm. "Most kids don't stick with it. It takes a lot of patience."

I looked at him, my chin set with a stubbornness I didn't know I possessed until that moment. My voice, usually quiet, came out clear and resolute. "I will." It wasn't a boast; it was a promise. A declaration. I felt it, deep down, a certainty that pulsed through me like the very music I longed to make.

Michael, my shadow, my other self, was standing two feet behind me – always two feet behind me, a silent guardian, a constant presence. He hadn't said a word, hadn't needed to. He'd watched me, his eyes mirroring my own fascination. As I made my choice, his own gaze had drifted to the corner of the stage. He moved with that same quiet certainty, not to the snare drum, which most kids gravitated towards, nor to the solitary bass drum. He walked straight to the full drum kit, a magnificent assemblage of gleaming cymbals and taut skins, a throne of rhythm. He sat down behind it, his small frame almost swallowed by the drums, but his posture was instantly natural, comfortable. His hands, which usually tapped rhythms on our knees, now rested lightly on the snare and tom-toms. He picked up a pair of sticks Mr. Coleman had laid out and tapped them together once, a soft, confident click. Mr. Coleman raised an eyebrow, a flicker of surprise and respect in his eyes. "You've played before?" he asked, his voice betraying a hint of skepticism.

Michael shrugged, a casual, almost dismissive gesture. "I've been playing my whole life," he said, looking at the drum kit like it was an old friend he was finally reunited with. "Just not on these." And a small, knowing smile played on his lips. He was right. He had. He'd been playing on my leg, on Mama's pots, on the rhythm of our own heartbeat. He just hadn't had the official instruments yet.

From that day forward, music became the third brother. It walked with us to school, its invisible presence a new layer in our silent conversations. We'd hum melodies, tap rhythms on our thighs, imagining the sounds we would make. It sat between us at lunch, a topic of endless discussion. What scales did Mr. Coleman show us today? What did that new piece sound like? Did you hear how Darius hit that chord last night? It filled our bedroom at night, a constant, comforting presence. I'd practice my trombone, propped on a pillow to muffle the sound so Mama wouldn't complain too much, the cold brass against my lips, my breath a steady, focused stream. I'd feel the vibrations, the subtle shifts in my embouchure, chasing the perfect note. Michael, meanwhile, would be tapping rhythms on his mattress with pencils, his feet thumping softly against the floor, keeping time. Our room, usually filled with the sounds of our whispered secrets, was now alive with a new language, a new harmony.

Together, we spent countless hours practicing. Not just in the band room or in our bedroom, but whenever we could steal a moment. We learned new songs, stumbled through difficult passages, encouraged one another to improve. I would play a phrase, a hesitant melody, and Michael would instantly find the beat underneath it, a foundational rhythm that gave my notes purpose and anchor. He'd lay down a complex rhythm, a syncopated masterpiece, and I would intuitively build a melody on top, weaving in and out, responding to his pulse. We didn't plan it. We didn't rehearse it in the traditional sense, marking out sections and counting bars. It just happened – the way breathing happens, the way light spills through a window. It was the way harmony happens when two voices are tuned to the exact same key, when two souls resonate with the same fundamental truth. It was more than music; it was communion. It was a glimpse into the divine.

The band room at school became³² our sanctuary. It was a large, echoey space, smelling faintly of old wood, valve oil, and dust, with posters of famous musicians tacked to the walls. In that room, the noise of the world outside, the cacophony of sirens and street vendors, the anxieties of bills and dwindling jobs that sometimes seeped into our two-family flat, all of it made sense. The chaos of the neighborhood, the sometimes-harsh realities of growing up Black on the east side of Detroit, reorganized itself into time signatures and chord progressions. It was a place where dissonance resolved into harmony, where uncertainty found its rhythm. Where a boy from a two-family flat in Detroit, a boy who knew the taste of struggle and the sting of injustice, could close his eyes, press cold brass to his lips, and feel something larger than himself move through the music, through his very being. It was a space where the world's clamor could be transmuted into something beautiful, something ordered, something soulful.

Mr. Coleman, our band teacher, noticed early. He wasn't just a clock-puncher; he was a true mentor, a quiet observer with a deep understanding of the language we were learning. He had a way of seeing past the fumbling fingers and the sometimes-sour notes, straight into the potential, into the spirit of the music.

"Chris," he said one afternoon after rehearsal, after the last squeaks and honks had faded, and the other kids were packing up their instruments, their chatter filling the room. He had pulled me aside, his voice low, almost conspiratorial. "You've got something. I don't know what to call it yet. It's not just skill, not just talent. It's... something else." He paused, searching for the words, his brow furrowed in concentration. "But don't let go of it. Whatever you do, don't let go of it."

I nodded, my heart swelling with a mix of pride and a vague, beautiful fear. I didn't know what to call it either. But I felt it – a profound pull, a deep, undeniable purpose. It was a sound that seemed to come from somewhere deeper than my lungs, deeper than the brass of the trombone, deeper than the very earth I stood on. It felt like it came from my soul, from the spirit of my ancestors, from the very heart of God. It was a whisper, a calling, a promise of a path yet unseen.

Every note I played, every breath I pushed through the horn, every melody I coaxed from its golden depths, carried me further away from the fears and struggles surrounding my neighborhood. It carried me away from the worry etched on Mama's face, from the distant sound of police sirens, from the concrete walls that sometimes felt like they were closing in. And it carried me closer to the hope of something greater. A hope that transcended our street, our city, even our time. A hope that spoke of connection, of purpose, of a future where the harmonies of grace could overcome any discord. And I knew, with a certainty that hummed in my blood, that Michael felt it too, drumming out that same hope, that same rhythm, right there beside me. We were just beginning to learn the language, but already, it felt like home.

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Mom and Pop

My parents, James and Eleanor McMillan, were more than just the people who gave me life; they were the very bedrock of it, the concrete foundation upon which my entire world was built. Growing up on Detroit's east side in the nineties, in a two-family flat that buzzed with the hum of shared existence and the faint, ever-present thrum of Motown classics bleeding through the walls from our downstairs neighbors' radio, Mom and Pop weren't just figures of authority. They were pillars of strength, yes, but more profoundly, they were living, breathing monuments to unwavering faith. Not the kind of faith that made a grand entrance on Sunday morning, dressed in its finest suit and hat, only to vanish like a phantom by Monday afternoon, leaving behind a faint scent of frankincense and good intentions. No, their faith was different. It was the kind that got woven into the very fabric of daily life, thread by thread, until you couldn't tell where the person ended and the prayer began. It was in the way Mom hummed spirituals as she kneaded dough, in the way Pop's strong hands meticulously repaired a neighbor's leaky faucet without ever asking for a dime, in the quiet, knowing glances they'd exchange when the weight of the world pressed a little too hard.

That faith wasn't a cloak they put³⁶ on; it was their skin, their bones, their very breath. It was the steady heartbeat of our home, a rhythm that pulled us through the lean times and celebrated the bountiful ones, always with gratitude, always with an eye towards something bigger than ourselves. Our block was a vibrant tapestry of lives, a symphony of front porch conversations, screen doors slamming, and kids' laughter echoing down the alleyways. And at the heart of it, Mom and Pop were the anchor, the quiet, unwavering presence that grounded us all, even when the winds of the city tried their hardest to blow us astray. They didn't preach from a pulpit, not in the traditional sense, but their lives were the most profound sermon I ever heard, a gospel sung not with words alone, but with every sacrifice, every act of kindness, every silent, steadfast prayer.

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My mother, Eleanor, prayed like ³⁷she cooked – with her whole body, with no shortcuts, with an understanding deep in her soul that what she was making would feed people long after she was done. And let me tell you, that woman could cook. Her kitchen, a small, sun-drenched space with linoleum floors that always felt cool beneath my bare feet, was the true sanctuary of our home. It hummed with life, a symphony of bubbling pots, sizzling skillet, and the rhythmic thump-thump of her knife against a cutting board. The air was a rich, complex perfume: the sharp tang of vinegar, the sweet earthiness of collard greens simmering low and slow with smoked turkey necks, the yeasty warmth of rising bread dough, and the comforting spice of her famous peach cobbler, its aroma clinging to the curtains, seeping into the very wood of the cabinets. She didn't just follow recipes; she felt them, her hands moving with a practiced grace, adding a pinch of this, a dash of that, always tasting, always adjusting, always infusing every dish with a love so potent it felt like a physical ingredient.

And just as she put her whole self³⁸ into every meal, she poured her entire being into prayer. I'd wake up some mornings, not to the blare of the alarm clock, but to a faint, melodic hum emanating from the living room, a sound so soft it felt woven into the pre-dawn quiet. Creeping out of my room, I'd find her there, a silhouette against the pale glow of the streetlights filtering through the sheer curtains, kneeling beside the worn velvet armchair. Her head would be bowed, her hands clasped loosely, sometimes rocking almost imperceptibly. Her lips would move, forming silent conversations with God, a private communion that filled the house with an invisible, palpable peace. Sometimes, a single word would escape, a whispered "Lord" or "Jesus," a sigh that carried the weight of the world and the boundless hope for its salvation. She prayed in the morning before anyone woke up, before the sun had fully cleared the rooftops of the two-family flats across the street, before the rumble of the D-DOT bus began its daily route down Gratiot Avenue, before the first smell of coffee or bacon hit the air.

She prayed at night after everyone³⁹ went to sleep, too. I remember nights when I couldn't sleep, maybe scared of a shadow or a strange sound from outside, and I'd hear her soft footsteps, then the gentle creak of the floorboards in the living room. She'd be there again, tending to her spiritual garden, watering it with whispered petitions. It wasn't just during these quiet, solitary moments either. Her prayers were woven into the tapestry of her day. I'd see her lips move in the car, stuck in traffic on Jefferson Avenue, a silent plea for safe passage. At the grocery store, standing in line at the checkout, I'd catch her eyes briefly close, a quick moment of gratitude or a request for provision. And at the kitchen sink, with her hands plunged deep into scalding dishwater, scrubbing the day's grime from plates and pots, she'd be praying. The clatter of cutlery, the splash of water, the low rumble of the Motown station Pop usually had on in the background – none of it drowned out the steady rhythm of her internal dialogue with the Almighty.

"Lord, cover my children," she'd ⁴⁰whisper, so softly that you'd miss it if you weren't paying attention. But Chris was always paying attention. I was always paying attention. There was something about the way her voice would crack just slightly on "children," a fragile strength that resonated deep within me. I knew she wasn't just asking for protection from scraped knees or bad grades. She was asking for covering from the darker things that lurked just beyond our front door, from the subtle temptations and the overt dangers that were as much a part of Detroit in the nineties as the sound of ice cream trucks in summer. She prayed for my sister, Keisha, for my older brother, Michael, and for me. She prayed for our minds, our bodies, our spirits. She prayed for our paths to be clear, for our hearts to stay soft, for our souls to remain tethered to the good. Her prayers were a shield, a silent, invisible force field that I felt around me, a warmth that chased away the chill of the outside world. It wasn't just a feeling, it was a knowing. I knew her prayers were working, actively shaping our lives, guiding us even when we didn't realize we were being guided. It was the truest form of love I knew, a relentless, tireless intercession, a mother's fierce devotion translated into divine language.

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My father, James, showed his faith differently. He didn't pray out loud as often, not with the same soft, constant hum as Mom, but his life itself was a prayer – steady, consistent, showing up when it was hard, staying when it would've been easier to leave. Pop was a man of few words, but every word he spoke carried the weight of granite and the warmth of a hearth fire. His faith was etched not in whispered pleas, but in the calluses on his hands, the deep lines around his eyes, and the quiet, unyielding strength of his presence. He wasn't a man to wear his heart on his sleeve, but his love for us, for Mom, for God, was evident in every deliberate step he took.

He worked the early shift at the plant, the automotive factories that were the lifeblood, and sometimes the heartache, of Detroit. The air in those places was thick with the smell of grease, metal, and the sweat of men who built the vehicles that moved a nation. He'd leave before the sun was even a rumor, his lunch packed by Mom, a thermos of black coffee clutched in his hand, the old Ford Fairmont groaning to life in the pre-dawn chill. I'd sometimes hear the soft click of the front door, then the distant rumble of the car, a sound that meant he was already out there, battling the world on our behalf. He'd spend eight, sometimes ten hours, on his feet, bending, lifting, tightening, the roar of machinery a constant assault on his ears, his body a well-oiled machine in its own right, moving with the practiced efficiency of years. He worked hard, hard enough to make a lesser man break.

But that wasn't enough. To keep ⁴²us in our home, to keep food on our table, to ensure we had what we needed and a little extra for what we wanted, Pop worked a late shift at the warehouse, too. After a brief nap, sometimes just an hour or two slumped in his armchair, he'd be off again, trading the clang of the factory for the cavernous silence of stacked boxes and the drone of forklifts. It meant he was often gone before we woke and returned only after the streetlights had come on, his shoulders heavy with the day's toil, his eyes carrying the weight of a man who worked two jobs to keep his family afloat. The drive between the plant, home, and the warehouse, navigating the potholed streets of Detroit, often felt longer than the actual work. Yet, no matter how bone-tired he was, no matter how long the day had been, he still made it home in time to sit at the dinner table with his family. It wasn't just about being physically present; it was about being there, fully engaged, fully attentive. That, more than any spoken word, was his testament of faith. It was his daily sacrifice, offered up, not in a temple, but in the grime and grit of industrial Detroit, a silent, powerful prayer of provision and perseverance.

He was the kind of man who didn't just provide; he maintained. Our house, our cars, our lives. If a faucet dripped, Pop fixed it. If the old furnace sputtered, he coaxed it back to life. He was a quiet pillar in the community, too, though he never sought recognition. Mrs. Johnson next door, whose husband had passed years ago, knew she could always count on Pop to clear her snow in winter, or check her smoke detector, or just sit on her porch for a few minutes and listen. He didn't offer grand speeches or perform flashy deeds; he simply showed up, consistently, reliably, a constant in a world that often felt anything but. His consistency was his sermon, his quiet strength, his unwavering belief that God had called him to be a provider, a protector, a rock for his family and his block.

Every evening, no matter how tired he was, no matter how long the day had been, the family gathered. It was the one non-negotiable ritual in our fast-paced, sometimes chaotic lives. The kitchen table was small, a round Formica top with chrome legs, nestled snugly in the corner between the stove and the back door that led to our tiny yard. It was usually covered in a plastic tablecloth, floral on weekdays, maybe something with a holiday theme if it was December. The food was simple, hearty, soulful – Mom’s fried chicken, cornbread, macaroni and cheese so creamy it practically melted on your tongue, those slow-simmered collard greens, sometimes a pot roast that had been cooking all afternoon, filling the house with its rich, savory promise. It wasn't gourmet, but it was sustenance for body and soul, prepared with love and served with grace.

But the ritual itself was sacred. ⁴⁴More than the food, more than the small table, it was the act of coming together, of breaking bread and sharing the day's burdens and triumphs. We'd all squeeze in: Mom at the head, Pop at the other, Michael, Keisha, and me filling the space in between. The clinking of forks against plates, the murmurs of conversation, the occasional burst of laughter from Keisha, who was still young enough that everything was a source of wonder – these were the sounds that formed the soundtrack of our evenings. The air would be thick with the comforting smells of supper, mingling with the faint, sweet scent of Mom's church perfume that still clung to her from earlier in the day, even after hours of cooking. Outside, the sounds of the block would drift in through the open window: kids playing hopscotch, the distant wail of a police siren, the bass thumping from a car cruising down the street. But inside, at our table, that world faded, replaced by the warmth and safety of family.

"How was school today?" his father would ask. It was always the first question, always directed at each of us in turn, starting with Michael, then me, then Keisha. And each child would answer, knowing that their father wasn't just asking — he was listening. Really listening. Not the distracted, half-hearted listening adults often gave children, their minds already on the next task, but the kind of listening that made you feel like your words were the most important sound in the room. His gaze would be steady, his eyes, tired from the day's labor, would soften as he met yours.

I remember one time I'd had a rough⁴⁵ day. A kid named Darrell had tried to snatch my lunch money, and while I didn't let him, the confrontation had left me shaky and a little scared. When it was my turn, I mumbled, "It was... okay." Pop paused, fork halfway to his mouth. "Just okay, Chris? What happened?" He didn't raise his voice, didn't accuse, just waited, his quiet attention a gentle pressure. I stammered out the story, my voice small, expecting a lecture or a dismissive wave. Instead, he just nodded slowly, his expression serious. "And what did you do?" he asked. I told him I stood my ground, that I didn't give in. "Good," he said, and that one word, delivered with such conviction, made me feel taller, stronger, seen. He didn't just listen to the words; he listened to the silence between them, to the tremor in my voice, to the unspoken emotions. He wasn't just gathering information; he was taking the pulse of our day, our inner lives, making sure we knew we were valued, our experiences worthy of his full, undivided attention. It was a silent lesson in empathy, in presence, in the sacred act of truly hearing another person.

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After dinner, before the dishes were done, before the Motown radio was tuned to a livelier station, before the evening chores began, came the prayer. It was the punctuation mark to our meal, the period at the end of a sentence that bound us together. The transition was always seamless, a natural flow from physical nourishment to spiritual sustenance. Pop would clear his throat, a soft, almost imperceptible sound that instantly commanded attention. The clatter of forks would cease, the low hum of conversation would fade.

"Let's bow our heads," his father⁴⁶ would say, his voice a steady baritone, and the entire household would go quiet. Even baby Keisha, who was usually a whirlwind of giggles and restless energy, would somehow sense the shift. Her tiny hands, often sticky with gravy or mashed potatoes, would fall still in her lap, her wide, innocent eyes fixed on her father's face, then slowly, instinctively, she'd lower her own head, mimicking ours. It was as if she understood, even at that tender age, that this moment mattered, that something sacred was unfolding, something beyond words and childish understanding. A hush would fall over the kitchen, broken only by the faint ticking of the old wall clock and the distant murmur of the city outside. The warmth of the food and the company would deepen into something more profound, something that settled deep in your bones.

The prayers weren't fancy. They weren't long. There were no dramatic gestures, no soaring rhetoric. But they were real. They were grounded in the everyday, rooted in the gratitude for what we had, and the quiet petitions for what we needed. Pop's voice, usually so measured, would take on a different timbre, a tender reverence. His words were simple, direct, yet they resonated with an ancient power, a connection to generations of faith that stretched back further than any of us could trace.

"Lord, thank you for this table. Thank you for this food, for these hands that prepared it, for these mouths that eat it. Thank you for this roof over our heads, for the warmth in our home, for the love that binds us. Thank you for these children. Keep them safe. Keep them humble. Keep them Yours." He'd pause, and in that silence, I always felt the weight of his love, the depth of his commitment. He wasn't just speaking to God; he was speaking for us, covering us, wrapping us in a blanket of divine protection. He'd often add a plea for the community, for the "folks on the block," for those struggling, for peace in the streets that sometimes felt anything but peaceful. It was a prayer that embraced not just our immediate family, but the wider circle of humanity around us, acknowledging our interconnectedness, our shared hopes and struggles. It was a prayer that made the small kitchen feel like the center of the universe, a place where heaven touched earth.

And then came the words that Chris would carry with him for the rest of his life — the words his parents repeated so often they became tattooed on his soul: "Stay active, pray up, and keep the faith; otherwise, the streets will swallow you whole."

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Those words weren't just spoken⁴⁸ at the dinner table. They were woven into the fabric of our lives, repeated like a mantra, a sacred incantation meant to ward off evil. I heard them when I left for school, Mom calling out from the porch. I heard them when Pop dropped me off at the Boys & Girls Club, his hand resting briefly on my shoulder. They came up when an ambulance siren wailed too close to our street, or when news spread of another young life lost too soon, too violently, just a few blocks over. They were a constant, a gentle but firm reminder of the precarious balance between the sanctuary of our home and the untamed wilderness just beyond its doorstep.

Chris didn't fully understand those words when he was eight. I heard them the way children hear all warnings – as background noise, as something adults say because adults say things like that. My world at eight was a vibrant kaleidoscope of scraped knees, stolen glances at comic books in the corner store, the thrill of riding my bike with no hands down the alley, the symphony of summer evenings filled with the whirring of lawnmowers and the shouts of kids playing street hockey until the streetlights came on. The "streets" to me then were the concrete paths I played on, the cracked pavement where we drew hopscotch grids, the familiar faces of neighbors on their porches. The idea of them "swallowing you whole" was a dramatic, almost fantastical image, like something out of a scary story, not a real threat. It felt distant, abstract, a grown-up concern that didn't quite penetrate the bubble of my childhood innocence.

Yet, even then, the words planted themselves like seeds. They buried deep, beneath the surface of my consciousness, lying dormant but alive. I'd see older boys, just a few years my senior, hanging out on corners, their laughter a little too loud, their eyes a little too hard. I'd catch glimpses of their lives from my bedroom window, the allure of their freedom, the dangerous sparkle in their defiance. I'd hear the rumble of their souped-up cars, the sharp bark of their arguments, the chilling silence that sometimes followed. And in those moments, the dormant seeds would stir, a faint, almost imperceptible tremor, a whisper of understanding beginning to form. The "streets" weren't just a place; they were a force, a hungry entity with a seductive pull, offering a false sense of power and belonging. My parents knew this, and their words were an anchor, a tether to a different path.

I didn't fully grasp their prescience then, the profound wisdom embedded in that simple phrase. But the words were there, a quiet promise, a potent charm, waiting. They would bloom later, at exactly the moment he needed them most, when the innocent allure of those streets would threaten to become a very real, very present danger, and the choice between light and shadow would demand not just understanding, but action. That seed, planted so tenderly by Mom and Pop, would one day blossom into the unwavering compass that guided me through the storm, proving that faith, indeed, was not just a belief, but a lived, embodied truth, passed down from one generation to the next, a harmony of hope echoing through time.

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The Move

Life, I'd learned early on, had a way of moving like a slow, deliberate current, carrying you along without much fuss. Then sometimes, it was like a sudden, unannounced rapids, rushing you into a place you never saw coming. This particular change, the one that rearranged the very air I breathed, felt like the latter. It started not with a roar, but with a whisper, a low hum of grown folks' talk that coiled around my sleeping form one late Detroit night.

My brother, Darius, was a heavy₅₁ sleeper, a gift I often envied. His breath was a steady, rhythmic hush beside me in our shared bed, the mattress dipped and worn in the middle from years of our growing bodies. But me? I was always a light sleeper, my ears tuned to the symphony of our two-family flat on the east side. The creak of the floorboards upstairs where the Millers lived, the distant wail of a siren on Van Dyke, the low thrum of Motown radio seeping from a neighbor's window like warm molasses. And then, the most important sounds of all: my mama and daddy in the kitchen.

They thought I was asleep. They always thought that. But a child learns to listen through walls the way other kids learn to read books, deciphering the nuanced shifts in tone, the pregnant pauses, the cadence of worry or joy. Our walls were thin, painted a shade of faded cream that seemed to absorb all the light and most of the secrets. I could practically feel the warmth radiating from the kitchen, smell the faint, lingering ghost of fried chicken from dinner, mixed with the sharper scent of Pine-Sol Mama used to wipe down everything twice a day. The floorboards were cold beneath my feet when I crept closer to the door, pressing my ear against the cool wood, my heart a tiny drum against my ribs.

"We got the call," Mama said, her voice a low murmur, softer than usual, but laced with an undeniable tremor. It was the kind of softness that meant something heavy was being said.

My daddy's response was immediate, a deep rumble that vibrated through the floor. "The call? Already?"

"Yes, baby. Just came in this afternoon. We can move."

The words hung in the air, thick and strange. Move. It wasn't a word we used lightly in our house. Move meant packing up the little bits of life we'd painstakingly assembled, meant leaving behind the familiar worn comfort of our corner of the world. My mind, still half-tangled in the threads of a dream, tried to grasp it, to make sense of the sudden shift in the steady rhythm of our lives. I heard the clink of a glass, then the soft scrape of a chair being pulled out.

"When?" Daddy asked, his voice now a little rougher, less questioning, more... resigned, maybe? Or was it something else?

"Next month. The house on Chestnut. Three bedrooms. A yard. Good schools." Mama's voice picked up speed, each detail a small, bright bead on a string. "It's got a big porch, James. And the bus stop is right at the corner. No more walking two miles in the snow for groceries."

A long silence followed. It wasn't the kind of silence that held anger or frustration, the kind that usually followed a disagreement about bills or a broken washing machine. No, this silence was different. It was deep, expansive, like the whole kitchen was holding its breath. I felt it in my chest, a curious emptiness that made my own breath hitch. Then, my daddy's voice, when it finally broke through the quiet, was thick with something I couldn't identify at the time, something that felt like a dam had just broken inside him. He didn't shout, didn't even raise his voice. He just said two words, soft and profound, words that carried the weight of years of quiet prayer and desperate hope.

"Thank God."

Later, much later, when I was grown⁵³ and had faced my own share of struggles, I'd recognize that sound. It wasn't just relief. It was weary triumph. It was a man, a Black man in Detroit in the nineties, who had worked two jobs, paid his tithes, kept his family together through lean times and hard knocks, finally seeing the fruit of his labor, the answer to a prayer he'd probably whispered every night into his pillow. It was the sound of a dream, long deferred, finally taking shape.

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The next few weeks were a blur, alright. A blur of cardboard boxes piled high in the hallway, smelling faintly of old paper and dust. A blur of bright orange packing tape stretched tight, securing the disparate pieces of our lives into neat, stackable cubes. And oh, the arguments. Not angry, shouting arguments, not between Mama and Daddy, but the kind of arguments that spring from the deep well of sentimentality versus practicality.

“James, we cannot get rid of this album collection! This is history! This is where we started!” Mama would declare, holding up a worn Motown vinyl, a glint in her eye.

“Baby, we got CDs now. Half these records scratched anyway. We ain't got room for all this in a new house, even a bigger one,” Daddy would counter, though I knew he loved those records just as much. He just had a knack for being the pragmatist.

Sometimes it was about a chipped ceramic bird Mama had kept on the windowsill for as long as I could remember, or Daddy's old fishing tackle box, rusted at the hinges but full of memories of weekend trips to Belle Isle. Every item held a story, a whisper of a past moment, and deciding what to keep felt like deciding which memories were worthy enough to carry forward.

My sister, Tamika, who was twelve and all dramatic grace, cried like the faucet was stuck on high. Her best friend, Renee, lived three houses down, and their bond was a sacred thing, forged over shared secrets whispered on stoops, double-dutch rhymes sung until their voices were hoarse, and scraped knees patched up with the same worn band-aids. Tamika's grief was raw, visible, her face blotchy and swollen as she clung to Renee one afternoon, promising they'd still see each other every single day, knowing full well it wouldn't be true. I watched her, a knot forming in my own stomach. Her pain was so honest, so unvarnished.

Darius, my older brother by two years, a master of cool detachment, pretended he didn't care. He walked around with his hands in his pockets, humming tunes under his breath, acting like the whole thing was just another Tuesday. But I knew him. I saw him spend an entire afternoon sitting on the porch, not talking to anyone, just watching the street. He wasn't watching the kids playing hopscotch or the ice cream truck jingling its way down the block. He was looking at the way the sunlight hit Mrs. Johnson's prize-winning roses in her front yard, the exact angle of the crack in the sidewalk where we'd carved our initials years ago, the rust-colored stain on the brick wall of the corner store where Mr. Leroy sold his famous candied apples. He was committing every single detail to memory, like a man staring at a fading photograph, knowing he might never see the original again.

Baby Keisha, bless her little heart⁵³, didn't understand anything. She toddled around the growing mountains of boxes, pulling out crumpled newspaper used for packing, delighted by the crinkle and tear. Her innocent obliviousness was probably a mercy, a sweet, oblivious bubble in the midst of our household's quiet storm of upheaval.

Me? I felt something I couldn't quite name. Not sadness, exactly, because the idea of a new house, a bigger house, held a certain thrilling promise. Not excitement, exactly, because excitement felt too simple, too untroubled. It was something in between. Something like standing at the very edge of a high diving board at the community pool, the sun hot on my back, the roar of the water below both terrifying and inviting. Wanting to jump, needing to jump, but afraid of the cold, vast unknown beneath the surface. It was the feeling of a chapter closing, its pages already yellowed, even as the ink for the next chapter remained unwritten.

Detroit's streets, the very asphalt and concrete, had formed me. They were etched into my bones. The corner store where Mr. Leroy, a man whose smile crinkled the corners of his eyes and whose voice was a comforting rumble, would slip me a free Now and Later every Friday after I ran an errand for Mama. Grape was my favorite, its tart sweetness a small, perfect reward. I could still smell the dusty shelves, the sweet scent of penny candy, the faint metallic tang of old coins in his register. That store was a hub, a meeting place, a whispered news agency for the whole block.

And the fire hydrant. Oh, the fire hydrant. Every summer, without fail, some daring older kid, usually Jamal Jenkins, would wrench open its cap, unleashing a geyser of cold, glorious water that transformed our street into a chaotic, joyous water park. We'd run through it, shrieking with laughter, the asphalt slick and cool beneath our bare feet, the sun sparkling on the spray. Those moments felt like pure, unadulterated freedom, a brief rebellion against the sweltering city heat. The neighborhood kids, Black and brown, rich in spirit if not in pocket, would all gather, splashing and playing until the sun dipped below the rooftops, painting the sky in hues of orange and purple.

The cracked sidewalk, too. It wasn't just a pathway; it was a canvas. I'd spent countless hours there, a stub of chalk clutched in my hand, drawing elaborate hopscotch grids, fantastical creatures, and, of course, my name. Chris. In letters so big and bold, you could see them from the end of the block, a temporary declaration of my existence, my mark on the world. The grit of the chalk, the rough texture of the concrete beneath my fingers – these were the textures of my childhood.

I was leaving all of it. The familiar faces, the comforting sounds, the smell of exhaust fumes and freshly cut grass mixed with collard greens cooking on a Sunday afternoon. The soulful strains of Smokey Robinson or Aretha Franklin drifting from open windows. The distant, rhythmic bounce of a basketball in an alley. The collective sigh of the neighborhood settling in for the night. This was my Detroit, my east side, and it was woven into the very fabric of who I was. And now, that fabric was being re-stitched.

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The day we arrived at our new home felt almost unreal. The moving truck, a rumbling behemoth of a thing, crawled slowly down a street that was too quiet, too clean. It felt like we'd driven into a different city altogether, a place plucked from the pages of a magazine I'd only ever flipped through in a doctor's waiting room. The air itself felt different, lighter, less dense with the familiar city grit.

The neighborhood was different in a way that Chris felt in his chest before he understood it in his mind. It was the kind of difference that settled deep in your bones, a quiet, almost reverent awe. The houses didn't lean or sag with the weight of years and neglect. They stood straight and proud, their paint fresh, their porches swept clean. The lawns were green, not the patchy, struggling green of our old block, but a lush, vibrant green, meticulously cut and edged. It was a verdant carpet stretching out, inviting you to run barefoot across it. And the trees. Oh, the trees. Not the scraggly, urban trees that pushed their way through cracks in the concrete, their roots fighting for purchase in a hostile environment. These were real trees, ancient and majestic, with thick, gnarled trunks that spoke of decades, perhaps centuries, of rootedness. Their branches reached toward the sky like arms raised in worship, their leaves a vibrant, rustling canopy that dappled the sunlight on the sidewalks. They offered shade and a sense of enduring peace, a stark contrast to the concrete jungle we'd left behind.

Children rode bikes on sidewalks⁵⁸ that were smooth and uncracked, their laughter light and carefree, not laced with the same street-wise caution I'd grown up with. Families sat on porches, sipping iced tea, not just observing, but truly living on their front steps. As our moving truck rumbled past, they didn't just glance; they smiled and waved, a genuine, open welcome that felt almost startling in its sincerity. It was a different kind of block culture here, one that seemed to hum with an unspoken promise of community, but a softer, gentler kind.

A man, his hair flecked with silver, walked his dog – a stately golden retriever – and offered a warm, easy smile as we pulled into our driveway. “Welcome to the neighborhood,” he called out, his voice rich and friendly. It wasn't a perfunctory greeting; it felt like a genuine invitation, a hand extended.

My brother, Darius, appeared at my side, as he always did, like a shadow or a second self. We stood there in the driveway, two boys from the east side, looking up at our new house. It wasn't just a house; it was an edifice, a beacon. It felt like a castle, white-painted brick gleaming in the afternoon sun, a wide porch stretching across the front like a welcoming embrace.

“It's so big,” Darius whispered, his voice hushed with wonder, a rare display of vulnerability from my usually stoic brother.

He was right. It wasn't a mansion, not really. But compared to the cramped, two-family flat we'd shared for all our lives, where every sound carried and every space was carefully negotiated, this house was a sprawling estate. Three bedrooms. That alone felt like an unimaginable luxury. A real kitchen, not just a galley space, but a room with an actual island, big enough for Mama to spread out her flour and sugar, for Daddy to carve the Sunday roast with room to spare. And the backyard. Oh, the backyard. It wasn't just a sliver of concrete and stubborn weeds. It was a patch of green grass, enclosed by a sturdy wooden fence, a private kingdom that their mother would eventually fill with the vibrant reds of tomatoes, the sweet perfume of roses, and the quiet, fervent whispers of her daily prayers. It was a space that promised not just play, but growth, sustenance, beauty.

"Boys," our father said, his voice booming with a mixture of exhaustion and profound satisfaction, as he carried a heavy box labeled 'KITCHEN' past us, his brow beaded with sweat but a small, proud smile playing on his lips. "Welcome home."

Home. The word landed differently here. In our old neighborhood, home was a place you returned to. A shelter from the sometimes harsh realities of the city, a base from which you ventured out into the world. It was the scent of Mama's cooking, the sound of Daddy's gospel records, the familiar creak of the stairs. It was protection, comfort, a known quantity, a warm blanket against the chill.

Here, in this new place, the word felt lighter, airier, imbued with a different kind of promise. Here, home felt like something you could grow into, something with high ceilings and wide-open windows, not just for fresh air, but for fresh possibilities. It felt like something that had room for the people they hadn't yet become, for the dreams they hadn't yet dared to whisper aloud. It was a canvas, still mostly blank, waiting for us to paint our lives

upon it.

That first night, after the last box had been hauled in and Mama had somehow, miraculously, conjured up a dinner of fried chicken and greens from the chaos of packed boxes, Darius and I finally lay in our new room. Our own room. For the first time in our lives, we didn't have to share. The space felt enormous, echoing with our whispers, the walls still bare and unadorned. The air, though, was different. It didn't carry the faint, ghost-like scent of old paint and shared history. It was clean, fresh, a little cool. We lay on the floor on makeshift beds made of blankets and pillows, staring up at the pristine, untouched ceiling, a vast, white expanse that seemed to stretch into infinity.

The silence was profound, broken only by the chirping of crickets from the freshly mown lawn outside, a sound that felt more pastoral than urban. It was a quiet different from the old flat's quiet, which was always just a breath away from the rumble of the city. This was a deeper, more peaceful quiet, a quiet that invited introspection.

"You think we'll like it here?" Darius asked, his voice soft, almost swallowed by the newness of the space. The question wasn't just for me; it was for himself, for the future. It held a wisp of the old anxiety, the lingering doubt that comes with leaving everything familiar behind.

I thought about it. I thought about the green lawns, the straight houses, the friendly waves. I thought about the way the light had fallen through the leaves of the big trees, like blessings. I thought about the quiet hum of possibility that vibrated through the air, distinct from the rougher thrum of the old neighborhood. I thought about Daddy's "Thank God," and Mama's hopeful whispers about good schools and a big porch. I thought about the emptiness of the room, waiting for our stories to fill it.

"Yeah," I said, my voice firm, surer than I even knew I was. "I think we already do."

Outside, the streetlights glowed steady and warm, casting long, soft shadows. No flickering, no buzzing, none of the weary struggle of old electrical grids fighting to stay alive. Just light. Pure, unwavering light, a beacon in the quiet, new night. It felt like a promise, a steady hand reaching out in the darkness.

And somewhere in the distance, carried on the gentle evening breeze, I could swear I heard music. Not the blare of a car radio, or the tinny sound from a boombox. This was something else. It was a melody, a soulful hum, possibly a faint gospel choir from a nearby church, or maybe just the echo of a neighbor's record player, spinning a sweet Motown tune. It was faint, almost imperceptible, but it was there, a thread of sound weaving itself into the quiet night, a familiar comfort in an unfamiliar place. It vibrated in my chest, a low, sweet thrum that settled the last of the unease in my heart. It wasn't just music; it was a feeling. It was the sound of hope, finding its harmony even in the newness, letting me know that no matter where we were, the spirit of Detroit, the rhythm of life, and the enduring grace of faith, would always find their way to us. And for the first time in a long time, I felt like I could truly breathe.

The Church

The summer heat of Detroit could be a cruel master, settling heavy and thick over the east side, pressing down on our two-family flat like a giant, invisible hand. We'd only been in the new place a few weeks, long enough for the boxes to be mostly unpacked but not long enough for it to feel like home. Not yet. The smell of fresh paint still clung to the walls, fighting a losing battle against the ghosts of previous tenants and the general musk of an old house settling into itself. The sounds were different too: instead of the familiar clang of the trolley on Gratiot, it was the distant rumble of I-94 and the ever-present thrum of Motown radio leaking from open windows up and down the block. We were in a new landscape, and a landscape needed an anchor.

It wasn't long, though, before that ⁶⁵anchor started to appear, brought to us by a woman whose very presence was a gravitational pull. Her name was Sister Loretta Mae Johnson, but everyone, and I mean everyone who knew her, just called her Auntie. She wasn't related by blood, not in the way the government kept records, but she was family in that deeper, more truthful way that Black folk understood. She was family because she'd been there for my mother when Mama was just a girl, learning to navigate the tricky currents of Detroit life. She was family because she showed up with a hot pan of cornbread when you were sick, and a sharp word when you needed it, and a laugh that could make the gloomiest day feel like sunshine breaking through the clouds.

Auntie lived just a few blocks over, in a sturdy brick bungalow with a porch swing that always looked inviting, even when the humidity was trying to steal your breath. Her house always smelled like cinnamon, furniture polish, and the faint, lingering scent of greens simmering low on the stove. This particular afternoon, she'd swept into our new kitchen like a benevolent storm, a bright floral dress rustling around her ample frame, a woven straw bag clutched in her hand. My mother, who'd been staring out the window at the unfamiliar street with a wistful look, brightened instantly.

"Girl, you look like you seen a ghost," Auntie declared, her voice a rich contralto that vibrated with warmth. She set her bag down on our still-bare kitchen table, revealing a foil-covered dish that immediately released the intoxicating aroma of peach cobbler. "But a ghost ain't gonna feed these babies, now is it?" She gave me and my younger brother, Michael, a wink, and we instantly gravitated toward the smell.

After we'd devoured the cobbler, ⁶⁶sitting around the kitchen table that still felt foreign, Auntie leaned forward, her eyes, dark and knowing, fixing on my mother. "Now, I ain't one to pry," she began, though her tone suggested she was absolutely going to pry, "but I know what it's like to be new in a place. And I know what it's like to be without a spiritual home." She paused, letting her words hang in the air, heavy with unspoken meaning. "Y'all need a church home," she said, finally, in the way that Black women say things that are equal parts invitation and commandment. Her voice was firm, yet laced with an undeniable tenderness. It wasn't a suggestion; it was a truth she knew we needed, laid out plain as day. "Come Sunday. Wear something nice. And bring those babies." She punctuated the last phrase with a pointed look at Michael and me, as if daring us to object. We just nodded, mesmerized by the peach cobbler sugar still clinging to our lips.

My mother didn't need convincing. She'd been looking for a church since the day they moved. The old church back in the flat's neighborhood, the one with the cracked stained-glass windows and the choir that sounded like angels themselves had descended, had been their anchor. It was where Mama had been baptized, where she'd learned to read scripture, where she'd found solace after her own mother passed. Leaving it had left a gap in our lives, a hollow space that nothing else had filled. I'd seen it in her eyes, a quiet yearning, a slight slump to her shoulders on Sunday mornings when the house felt too quiet, too empty. She'd tried a few places, small storefront churches she'd found advertised in the local paper, but they hadn't clicked. One was too loud, another too stiff, none of them had that feeling she carried in her heart for what church ought to be. Auntie's invitation wasn't just a suggestion; it was a lifeline, extended with love and a clear understanding of what a family needed to

thrive in a new place.

But Chris hesitated. Not because I⁶⁷ didn't want to go — I'd grown up in church the way fish grow up in water. It was just what you did. Sunday was church. Period. It was the rhythm of our lives, as fundamental as breathing. Every Sunday morning, the smell of my mother's "good" perfume, the rustle of starched clothes, the low hum of gospel music from the radio while she braided my sister's hair — these were the immutable laws of my childhood universe. Church was safety, predictability, a warm embrace in a world that could sometimes feel big and bewildering. I knew the hymns, knew the order of service, knew when to stand and when to sit. I knew the ushers who slipped me peppermints, the deacons who boomed their greetings, the older ladies who pinched my cheeks and told me I was "getting so big."

But this was a new church, with new people and new pews and new rules I didn't know yet. The very thought made a knot tighten in my stomach. What if they sang different songs? Not just different hymns, but different arrangements? What if the choir sounded thin, or off-key? What if the pastor preached different? Not with the gentle, storytelling cadence of Reverend Miller, who always made the Bible stories come alive like Saturday morning cartoons. What if this new pastor shouted and stomped and made the sermon feel like a scolding instead of a blessing? What if the kids there didn't like him? That was the biggest fear, the one that coiled deepest. At eight years old, navigating the intricate social hierarchy of the school playground was already a minefield. The church kids were supposed to be different, kinder, but what if they weren't? What if they already had their cliques, their inside jokes, their established pecking order? What if I was just another outsider, another new face trying to fit in? The uncertainty felt like a heavy blanket, smothering the faint flicker of excitement that Auntie's cobbler

had stirred.

Sunday morning arrived, bright and insistent, a perfect Detroit summer day already promising heat by nine o'clock. The sun streamed through the thin curtains of my bedroom, illuminating dust motes dancing in the air, but I still felt a shadow of dread. My mother, however, was a force of nature when it came to Sunday service. Her energy was palpable, a quiet but determined hum that permeated the entire flat. The smell of her hot comb, the sizzle of hair grease, mingled with the lingering scent of breakfast – grits and bacon, a rare treat on a weekday, but a Sunday staple.

"Chris, Michael, you hear me? Time to get a move on!" Her voice, usually soft, carried a certain edge on Sunday mornings, an unspoken command that tolerated no dawdling. I could hear my older sister, Renee, already complaining from the bathroom about whose turn it was for the mirror.

My mother answered all my silent objections, the ones swirling unspoken in my head, by simply handing me a pressed shirt. It was a crisp, light blue button-down, starched so stiff it felt like cardboard, smelling faintly of the dryer sheet and my mother's careful ironing. "Put that on and get in the car," she said, her expression leaving no room for argument. There was a gentle patience in her eyes, though, a silent understanding that I was nervous. She didn't need to say anything; her actions spoke volumes. She smoothed the collar of my shirt, adjusting it just so, her fingers lingering for a moment on my shoulder. It was a small touch, but it carried the weight of her love and her quiet

assurance.

Getting ready was a meticulous process. First, the bath, then the fresh clothes. My brothers and I were lined up, inspected for stray crumbs, untucked shirts, or scuffed shoes. Mama was a stickler for presentation, especially on Sundays. "We go to God's house looking our best," she always said, "because it shows respect." I remember the struggle of buttoning the stiff cuffs, the way the collar felt tight against my throat, a minor discomfort for the sake of propriety. Michael, ever the fidgeter, groaned under Mama's watchful eye as she tried to smooth down his cowlick. Renee, already a teenager, emerged from her room looking impossibly elegant in a floral dress and a wide-brimmed hat, carrying herself with the practiced grace of a young woman entering her own.

The car ride was quiet, save for the low murmur of gospel music on the radio – a familiar voice singing of mercy and grace, a comforting sound that slowly began to chip away at my anxiety. We drove down streets I hadn't seen before, past rows of other brick bungalows, some well-tended with vibrant flowerbeds, others showing the wear and tear of time, peeling paint and overgrown hedges. Children were playing hopscotch on sidewalks, their laughter echoing in the humid air, but as we got closer to our destination, the street grew quieter, more reverent. People were walking, dressed in their Sunday best, their faces alight with anticipation.

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The church itself was a brick building on a corner lot, modest but well-kept. It wasn't a grand cathedral, no towering spires or intricate gargoyles, but its simplicity held a certain dignity. The bricks were a warm, earthy red, softened by years of Detroit weather, and the white trim around the windows and door glowed clean in the morning sun. A sturdy wooden cross, unadorned and powerful in its plainness, stood above the double doors, a silent sentinel watching over the neighborhood. Below it, a neatly painted sign read: All Are Welcome. Come As You Are. I read the words, tracing them with my eyes, and a small seed of hope began to sprout in my chest. Come As You Are. That sounded like a promise, like an invitation for someone exactly like me, nervous and new.

People were already gathered outside, a vibrant tapestry of Detroit's Black community. Men in sharply pressed suits, ties knotted just right, their shoes gleaming, stood in small groups, heads bowed in conversation or hands clasped in hearty greetings. Women, resplendent in their Sunday hats – some wide-brimmed and feathered, others small and elegant, like crowns – fanned themselves gently with church bulletins, their perfume a fragrant cloud that mingled with the humid air and the exhaust fumes from passing cars. Children, like me and Michael, fidgeted in clothes they clearly didn't want to be wearing, their shiny shoes scuffing the pavement, but even they carried a certain air of expectation. Yet, despite the underlying currents of heat and the natural restlessness of children, there was an overriding sense of peace. Everyone was smiling. Everyone. It wasn't the forced, polite smile you sometimes saw; it was a deep, genuine warmth that radiated from their eyes, a shared understanding of the sacred space they were about to enter.

As Auntie, who had arrived just before us, spotted us pulling up, she beamed, her face lighting up even more. She waved us over, her arms wide. "That's them! That's my family!" she called out, her voice a joyful announcement. Suddenly, all those smiling faces turned towards us, their expressions shifting from general warmth to specific welcome. It felt like being bathed in sunshine.

The moment Chris stepped inside the sanctuary, something shifted. It wasn't just walking through a door; it was like entering a different dimension, a sacred pocket of air within the bustling city. The air was different. Warmer. Not from the heating, because it was already a sweltering summer day, but from the people. It was a palpable warmth, a collective spirit of love and acceptance that enveloped me the moment I crossed the threshold. The scent was different too – a rich, complex aroma of polished wood, old hymnals, communion wine, and the myriad perfumes and colognes of the congregation, all blended into a unique, comforting church smell that was utterly distinct from the outside world. The light, filtered through tall, clear windows, seemed softer, gentler.

They turned and looked at the family the way people look at someone they've been expecting, not with curiosity or judgment, but with an open-hearted readiness. Hands reached out, warm and firm, clasping my mother's hand, then mine, then Michael's. Smiles widened, revealing gold teeth and deep laugh lines. Voices, rich and melodious, called out from every direction, a chorus of genuine welcome: "Welcome!" a stately usher in a white dress uniform declared, her voice like velvet.

"Come on in, family!" a man with a booming laugh called from a pew halfway down the aisle. "Glad to have you!"

"Is this Auntie's people?" a woman with a magnificent purple hat asked, her eyes twinkling. "Come sit up front! We got plenty of room for new faces!"

Auntie, her arm wrapped around ⁷³my mother's waist, beamed with pride, guiding us down the center aisle. The stares weren't uncomfortable; they were embracing. Each greeting was a balm, each smile a reassurance. The initial knot of anxiety in my stomach began to unravel, replaced by a growing lightness, a sense of being seen and acknowledged, not as an outsider, but as an arrival.

We settled into a pew near the front, just behind Auntie, the polished wood cool beneath my fingers. I shifted, trying to find a comfortable spot, my eyes wide, taking it all in. The sanctuary was simple but beautiful, with high ceilings, tall arched windows, and dark wooden pews that gleamed with care. A large, ornate pulpit dominated the front, flanked by a choir stand. The atmosphere hummed with anticipation, a quiet electricity that vibrated through the air. And then the music started.

It didn't begin with a sudden crash or a fanfare. It started with a low, resonant rumble that seemed to rise from the very foundations of the earth, from somewhere behind the pulpit. A Hammond organ. Oh, that sound. It was deep and warm, like thunder you could feel in your chest, a vibration that resonated not just through the floorboards but through my bones. It was a sound that spoke of ancient things, of sorrow and joy, of struggle and triumph, all rolled into one magnificent, swirling chord. I looked up, trying to pinpoint the source, and caught a glimpse of a man in a white suit, his fingers dancing over the keys, his head tilted slightly as if listening to a secret conversation only he could hear. His foot worked the bass pedals with a gentle, rhythmic pressure, adding a profound depth to the sound that made the air itself feel thick with music.

Then, a drummer – a real drummer, not the kind who just keeps time with a polite tap-tap-tap, but the kind who speaks through the skins, whose sticks were extensions of his very soul – laid down a groove. It was a gospel beat, a syncopated pulse that was both intricate and utterly compelling. The kick drum was a heartbeat, the snare a sharp crack, the cymbals a shimmering exhalation. It wasn't loud, not yet, but it was powerful, a steady, infectious rhythm that made the pews vibrate, that stirred something primal and undeniable in my spirit. I felt it in my feet, a subtle urge to tap, to sway. The drummer, a young man with intense focus, seemed to be having a conversation with the organist, a call and response that built a foundation of sound so solid, so undeniable, it felt like the very ground of our being.

And then the choir stood up. They were dressed in long, flowing robes of deep purple, their faces serene, expectant. They were men and women, young and old, a diverse array of voices waiting for their moment. The organ swelled, the drums intensified, and then, as one, they released something. It wasn't just singing. It was an outpouring, a torrent of sound that poured out like water breaking through a dam after a long, dry season – rich, full, layered, alive. Altos and sopranos and tenors braided together in a harmony that didn't just fill the room. It filled Chris.

The notes were physical entities, pressing against my eardrums, vibrating behind my eyes. The sopranos soared, crystalline and pure, like doves taking flight. The altos offered a warm, comforting cushion, a blanket of sound. The tenors provided the drive, the urgency, pushing the melody forward. And beneath it all, the bass voices, deep and resonant, grounded the sound, giving it weight and power. It was a sound that spoke of centuries of faith, of ancestors singing through sorrow and joy, of hope whispered in the dark and shouted in the light. It wasn't just a song; it was a prayer, a testimony, a communal declaration of

belief.

I sat in the pew, eight years old, my hands gripping the edge of the polished wooden seat, my knuckles white. I was mesmerized, utterly captivated by this wall of sound, this spiritual symphony. The music flowed over me, through me, washing away the last vestiges of my apprehension. It was like feeling the warmth of the sun after a long winter, or the sudden, sweet relief of rain after a drought. It was pure, unadulterated joy, tempered with a profound sense of peace. And then, I felt tears on my cheeks that I didn't remember crying. They weren't tears of sadness or fear, but something else entirely – tears of recognition, of belonging, of a deep spiritual release I didn't have words for. They traced warm paths down my face, a silent testament to the power of the moment.

My brother Michael, sitting next to me, always more attuned to my silent world than anyone else, elbowed me gently. "You okay?" he whispered, his small face etched with concern.

I nodded, unable to speak, my throat tight with emotion. But I wasn't okay. I was something bigger than okay. I was home. It was a profound and instantaneous understanding, a knowing that settled deep in my bones. This wasn't just a new church; it was my church. These weren't just new people; they were my people. The music had sung me home, ushered me into a space where my spirit felt seen, heard, and utterly embraced.

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Before long, the church became ⁷⁶a second home for Chris and his family. It wasn't just a Sunday morning obligation; it became the heartbeat of our week, the rhythm that anchored our lives in our new Detroit neighborhood. My mother bloomed, her shoulders visibly lighter, her smile more frequent. She joined the usher board, her stately grace perfect for welcoming newcomers. Renee, after her initial teenage eye-rolls, found her place in the youth choir, her powerful alto voice adding to the soaring harmonies. Michael, always energetic, gravitated towards the children's ministry, where he could play and learn with other kids his age. And me? I found myself drawn to the music, to the stories, to the quiet power that emanated from the pulpit.

The sermons inspired them — not the shouting, fire-and-brimstone kind that made you feel like you were perpetually on the brink of eternal damnation, but the quiet, steady, look-you-in-the-eye kind that reminded Chris of his father. Our pastor, Reverend Ezekiel Thorne, was a man of medium height with kind eyes that crinkled at the corners when he smiled, and a voice that was a warm, resonant baritone. He didn't need to shout to get his point across; his words were like water, slowly but surely eroding the hardness in your heart. He spoke with a gentle conviction, his hands often clasped in front of him, or occasionally raising one to emphasize a point, never with drama, but with deep sincerity. He had a way of making the Bible feel like it was written yesterday, for the people in this room, about the problems on this block, in this very city of Detroit. He didn't preach from a lofty pedestal; he preached from the trenches of shared human experience. He'd talk about job layoffs, about struggling to pay bills, about raising children in a challenging world, always weaving in scripture not as a judgment, but as a guide, a source of strength and comfort.

I remember one particular Sunday, the air heavy with unspoken anxieties about the city's economic downturn, Reverend Thorne stood before us, his gaze sweeping over the congregation, meeting each person's eyes with a silent acknowledgment. "We live in a world that tells us we need grand things, big solutions, overwhelming power to overcome our obstacles," he began, his voice soft, almost conversational. "It tells us our faith has to be a mountain, a towering peak that can't be moved." He paused, letting the words settle. Then, he held up his thumb and forefinger, an inch apart. "But the Lord teaches us otherwise. He says, 'Faith the size of a mustard seed.' That's all it takes." He looked directly at me then, or so it felt, his eyes warm. "Not a mountain of faith. Not a river. Just a seed. Just enough to say,

'God, I don't understand, but I trust You anyway.'

Those words hit me with the force of a revelation. In a world that often felt too big, too complex, too demanding for a small boy, the idea of a mustard seed faith was a comfort. It meant I didn't have to have all the answers. I didn't have to be strong all the time. I just had to have a tiny spark of trust, a willingness to believe, even when things didn't make sense. I fumbled for the small pencil tucked into the bulletin rack on the back of the pew in front of me and wrote those words in the margin of my bulletin, my handwriting still a bit wobbly: Mustard seed faith. Trust anyway. I'd keep that bulletin for years, tucked into my Bible, the paper growing soft and yellowed with time, those words a constant, quiet reminder.

Through youth activities, fellowship gatherings, and Sunday potlucks that rivaled Grandma Lois's cooking, Chris found himself surrounded by people who genuinely cared about him. The church wasn't just a building; it was a living, breathing organism of interconnected lives. After service, the fellowship hall would erupt with sound and laughter. The youth group wasn't just about Bible study; it was about pizza parties and bowling nights, about community service projects where we cleaned up local parks, and lively discussions about what it meant to live our faith in the real world. I learned to play checkers with Deacon Johnson, a man whose hands were gnarled from years of working at the auto plant but whose smile was as soft as a summer cloud. Sister Eleanor, who taught Sunday school, had a way of explaining scripture that made it feel like a grand adventure, turning figures from the Old Testament into heroes and heroines I could relate to.

And then there were the potlucks.⁷⁹ Oh, the potlucks! They were epic, a sensory feast that spilled out of the fellowship hall and into the very air of the neighborhood. The smells alone could make your stomach growl: collard greens simmering with smoked turkey, macaroni and cheese baked to a golden crust, fried chicken crisp and juicy, sweet potato pie fragrant with nutmeg and cinnamon, peach cobbler bubbling with syrupy goodness. It was a symphony of aroma and flavor that could rival even Grandma Lois's legendary Sunday dinners, a comparison I didn't make lightly. Each dish was a labor of love, a piece of someone's heart offered to the community. We'd line up, plates in hand, the clatter of forks and the murmur of conversation creating a joyful din. I remember the laughter, the easy camaraderie, the way everyone made sure every child had a plate piled high, and that no one, absolutely no one, left hungry. It was in these moments, sharing a slice of warm pie with a newly made friend, or listening to the older women swap stories while clearing tables, that I understood the true meaning of communion.

I was no longer the nervous boy with the pressed shirt and the tight throat. I was Chris, part of the youth group, recognized by the ushers, smiled at by the choir, and hugged by Auntie every single Sunday. These people cared about me. Not because they had to, not because they were related by blood, but because that's what the church was — a family you chose, and that chose you back. It was a covenant of love, a sacred bond forged in faith, music, and the shared journey of hope in the heart of Detroit. And for a young boy finding his way in a new city, that chosen family was everything.

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The Water

The decision came on a regular⁸¹ Wednesday evening, though there wasn't a thing regular about the way it settled in my spirit. Wednesdays, back then in our two-family flat on Detroit's east side, meant the sweet, slow simmer of collard greens on the stove, the scent of garlic and smoked ham hocks weaving through the thin walls, mingling with the faint, metallic tang of motor oil from Mr. Johnson's perpetually open garage next door. It meant the insistent, soulful wail of Aretha Franklin or Sam Cooke drifting from Mama's radio in the kitchen, a constant soundtrack to the rhythm of our lives. And it meant youth Bible study, down at True Vine Missionary Baptist, a squat brick building that always smelled of lemon polish and the faint, sweet decay of old hymnals.

I was maybe eleven, teetering ⁸²on that precarious edge between childhood's boundless wonder and the first stirrings of a young man's questions. My clothes still smelled faintly of the playground's dust and the faint, lingering sweetness of grape Kool-Aid, even after Mama made me change into my 'church clothes' – usually a pair of stiff khakis and a polo shirt that felt too tight around the neck. Brother James, our youth pastor, was a man built like a sturdy oak, with a voice that could rumble like thunder one minute and soothe like a summer breeze the next. He had this way of looking at you, deep into your eyes, like he could see the whole messy map of your young soul and still find something beautiful there. He didn't preach at us so much as he leaned in, like he was sharing a secret.

This particular night, the fluorescent lights hummed a low, drowsy tune above us, casting a yellowish glow on our faces. The air was thick with the scent of cheap air freshener and the nervous energy of a dozen kids who'd rather be outside playing ball or listening to the latest Motown cut. Brother James had been talking about purpose, about the difference between living and merely existing, and then he paused, letting the silence stretch like a pulled taffy. He walked to the edge of the small stage, his hands clasped behind his back, his gaze sweeping over each of us.

"Who are you living for?" he asked, his voice low, almost a whisper.

The question hit the room like a sudden drop in temperature. It sounded simple, innocent even, the kind of thing an adult asks to make you feel smart. But it wasn't. It hung in the air, heavy and sharp, piercing through the usual chatter and fidgeting. A few kids shifted in their chairs, the plastic groaning under their weight. Dwayne, whose sneakers always seemed to squeak no matter how still he tried to be, cleared his throat.

Then, a quiet voice, belonging to⁸³ Sarah Jenkins, a girl with braids that clicked like beads when she moved, answered, "God." Her voice was soft but firm, like she'd practiced it.

Another boy, Michael, who was always trying to impress, puffed out his chest a little and said, "My family." He glanced at his older brother in the back, daring him to challenge it.

Someone in the back, probably Jamal, notorious for his quick wit and even quicker mouth, muttered, "Myself." It got a nervous ripple of laughter, a quick, almost embarrassed sound. But Brother James didn't smile. He just held our gaze, his expression unreadable.

He let the laughter die, let the silence reclaim the space. Then he leaned forward, his voice dropping to that intimate, confidential tone again. "Honest answer," he said, and Jamal, who'd been slumping, straightened up a bit. "Most of us, truth be told, are living for whatever's loudest. Whatever's closest. Whatever feels good right now." He paused, letting that sink in, letting us consider our own loud desires, our immediate comforts. "But God isn't loud," he continued, his voice picking up a quiet strength. "Not in the way the world is. God isn't always close, not in the way your mama's hug is, or your friend's hand in a fight. And God doesn't always feel good. He doesn't always feel like ice cream on a hot day, or a winning lottery ticket."

He walked closer to the edge, looking directly at me then, or so it felt. "He feels right." Brother James's eyes were shining now, a deep, knowing warmth. "And there's a difference. Good is fleeting. Right is forever."

I didn't answer out loud. My voice, if I'd tried to speak, would have been caught somewhere in my throat, tangled with a lump of sudden, profound understanding. But something in my chest — the same thing that responded to the deep, resonant thrum of the bass drum at Sunday service, the same thing that vibrated when Mama sang those old spirituals low and sweet in the kitchen, the same thing that hummed between the raw, sometimes rough-and-tumble reality of the block and the quiet, comforting certainty of the blessing Mama spoke over our dinner table every night — stirred. It wasn't a flutter, not a tremor. It was more like a deep, slow awakening, like an underground river finally finding its way to the surface. It was a sense of alignment, a feeling that a piece of myself I hadn't known was missing had just clicked into place. Right. That was the word. Not just a word, but a feeling that resonated through my bones.

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The walk home that evening felt different. The streetlights cast long, dancing shadows, turning familiar cracks in the sidewalk into mysterious canyons. The usual symphony of the east side — distant sirens, the rumble of a bus, the barking of a dog, the faint, tinny echo of a Motown tune from an open window — seemed to hold a new meaning, a deeper harmony. I heard it all, but it was like a filter had been placed over my ears, allowing the essence of the sounds to reach me, rather than just the noise. The cool night air, thick with the scent of damp asphalt and the lingering sweetness of honeysuckle from Mrs. Henderson's yard, felt crisp against my face, like a cleansing.

Mama was in the kitchen, just as I'd known she would be. The scent of those collard greens, now fully infused with their savory magic, mingled with the earthy aroma of cornbread baking. She was humming along to Marvin Gaye, her back to me, stirring something in a pot on the stove. The kitchen, usually a bustling hub of activity, was quiet save for Marvin's smooth tenor and Mama's gentle hum. My brother, David, was likely in his room, lost in a comic book. Tamika was probably on the phone, giggling with one of her friends. Darius was probably still outside, trying to coax a few more minutes out of daylight with his friends. And baby Keisha was already asleep, a soft, dreaming bundle.

I stood in the doorway, watching Mama. Her shoulders swayed gently with the music, her movements economical and graceful, even when just stirring a pot. She was strength and love personified, my Mama. Everything good and solid in my young life radiated from her. "Mama," I said, my voice a little rougher than I intended, a little more uncertain.

She turned, her smile soft and immediate, the kind that reached her eyes and crinkled the corners. "Hey, baby. Bible study over already? You're quiet tonight." She reached for a dishtowel, wiping her hands, her gaze searching my face. She always knew. She always saw past the words to the feelings underneath.

I took a deep breath, the collard greens and cornbread filling my lungs. "Mama," I said again, firmer this time, the conviction in my chest blooming into spoken word. "I want to be baptized."

She didn't cry. Not then, not a single ⁸⁶tear. Her smile widened, a slow, radiant blossoming that seemed to light up the whole kitchen, brighter than the yellow overhead light. She put the dishtowel down, her movements deliberate, unhurried. She walked over to me, her hands reaching for my face, her touch gentle, warm, and calloused from years of working and loving. Her thumbs stroked my cheeks, and I leaned into the familiar comfort of her touch.

"Baby," she whispered, her voice thick with emotion, a tremor I felt in her fingertips. Her eyes, those deep, knowing eyes, glistened, but the tears stayed held back, brimming on the edge. "I've been praying for this day since before you were born. I've been praying for the day you'd feel God's call in your own heart, not just in mine." The depth of her faith, the sheer unwavering power of it, was a tangible thing in that kitchen, a warmth that wrapped around me like a blanket. It was a blessing made manifest.

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The news spread through our small household like wildfire. Not a destructive blaze, but a warm, comforting hearth fire, drawing us all closer. David, my older brother by two years, was the first to hear. He'd come out of his room, drawn by the unusual quiet in the kitchen, and found Mama holding me, her face glowing. When I told him, his initial reaction was a surprised blink. David was always the more pragmatic one, grounded in the tangible world of baseball stats and bike repairs. But then, a thoughtful look settled on his face, a mirroring of the quiet stirring that had happened in my own chest.

"You really mean it, Chris?" he asked, his voice softer than usual.

"Yeah," I said, my conviction solidifying with each utterance. "I do."

He chewed on his lip for a moment, looking from me to Mama, whose eyes were still shining. David and I shared a room, and we shared secrets, unspoken understandings that only brothers can. We'd sat through countless Sunday services together, heard countless sermons. He'd seen Mama's faith, Papa's quiet devotion, had absorbed it through osmosis. He knew the music, the hymns, the way the Spirit could move a congregation. I think he'd been feeling it too, perhaps, just waiting for someone else to articulate it first.

"Then I want to too," he said, his voice gaining a quiet resolve. "If you do it, I do it." It wasn't just about following his younger brother; it was about recognizing a truth he'd been wrestling with himself. It was a pact, a shared journey.

Next came Tamika, my older sister, a whirlwind of teenage energy and bright, bold dreams. She heard us talking, probably from the hallway where she'd been pretending not to eavesdrop. She burst into the kitchen, her eyes wide. Tamika was always a leader, never one to follow blindly. She had a fiery spirit, a quick mind. But when Mama explained, her usual boisterous energy softened. She listened, her head tilted, and then a profound stillness settled over her.

"It makes sense," she said slowly, almost to herself. "All the things Mama and Papa talk about. All the hymns we sing. It's... it's like coming home, but to a place you ain't never really been before." Her voice, usually so confident, held a tremor of awe. "Yeah," she declared, her eyes meeting mine, "I want to be baptized too. I want to feel that peace you're talking about."

Darius, the family clown, the one who always had a comeback, a joke, a way to lighten any serious moment, was tougher. He wandered in from outside, smelling faintly of street dust and something sweet, probably candy. When he heard the news, he tried to play it cool, stuffing his hands in his pockets, affecting a nonchalant shrug. "Baptized? What, like, dunked in water? Y'all gonna get all wet and wrinkly." He rolled his eyes for dramatic effect.

Mama just looked at him, her expression firm but patient. "Darius, this ain't about getting wrinkly. This is about your soul. It's about making a promise to God."

He tried to keep up the bravado, but I saw it. I saw the way his shoulders hunched just a fraction, the way his eyes darted from Mama's steady gaze to my resolute one. And then, as he stood there, trying to look unaffected, a tell-tale tremor started in his hands. He tried to hide them, clenching his fists, but the slight tremble was there, a silent testament to the fear and the yearning that warred within him. He was younger than me, but not so young that he didn't feel the pull of the Spirit, the weight of a decision like this. He might act like it was no big deal, might try to laugh it off, but everyone could see his hands shaking, just a little.

Finally, he exhaled, a long, shaky breath. "Okay," he mumbled, barely audible. "Okay, I wanna do it too. If everybody else is doing it." He still tried to make it sound like peer pressure, but the underlying sincerity was unmistakable. He just needed to find his own way to say yes. Even baby Keisha, who was too young to understand, toddled over, tugging on Mama's skirt, her wide eyes taking in the unusual seriousness of the moment.

That night, around the dinner table, the usual lively chatter was replaced by a different kind of energy. Mama spoke softly, explaining what baptism meant, not just as a ceremony, but as a public declaration, a rebirth. Papa, who was often a man of few words, especially when Mama was speaking, listened intently, his eyes moving from one child to the next, his expression a mixture of profound pride and deep understanding. He shared a story from his own youth, about his baptism in a river down in Alabama, how the cold water had felt like fire and ice all at once, burning away the old and welcoming the new. His voice was low, gravelly, but it held a powerful resonance that commanded our attention. He didn't preach, he just shared his truth, his lived faith. The greens tasted richer that night, the cornbread sweeter, infused with the quiet joy and solemnity of our shared decision.



The week leading up to the baptism was a blur of nervous anticipation and quiet preparation. Mama insisted we all read specific scriptures together each night, passages about John the Baptist, about Jesus in the Jordan River, about the meaning of repentance and new life. She didn't just read; she explained, she connected the ancient words to our everyday lives in Detroit. "See, baby," she'd say, tracing a finger over a verse, "this ain't just history. This is your story too. This is about washing away what don't serve you, making room for what God wants to build in you."

I remember the smell of her skin, the warmth of her arm around me as we sat on the worn floral couch, the lamplight soft on the pages of the family Bible, its leather cover smooth and cool beneath my fingertips. She talked about the commitment, about how it wasn't a magic spell, but the beginning of a walk, a journey that would have its ups and downs. "You gonna stumble, Chris," she'd warned, her voice gentle but firm. "We all do. But the promise is, God's always there to pick you up. And this water, it's a sign that you ready to let Him."

My own feelings were a tangled knot of excitement and trepidation. I was eager for this profound change, this feeling of "rightness" to fully manifest. But I was also a little scared. What would it feel like? Would I be different? Would the world look different? I found myself humming hymns more often, tunes that had always been background noise now carrying new weight, new meaning. The rhythms of the church, the deep bass lines, the soaring sopranos, the way the organ could swell and fill every corner of the sanctuary – it all began to feel like a language I was finally learning to speak, not just hear.

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Sunday arrived, a day crisp and⁹¹ bright, promising a long, warm Detroit summer. The air was already thick with the scent of blooming hydrangeas and the faint, sweet exhaust of cars. This wasn't just any Sunday; this was the Sunday. The morning felt charged, vibrating with a special kind of energy. We woke early, the house already alive with the rustling of clothes and the murmur of hushed voices. Mama made a special breakfast – fluffy pancakes and crispy bacon, a rare treat on a Sunday morning, a subtle acknowledgment of the significance of the day.

We all dressed in our finest. Papa, usually meticulous, was even more so, his suit pressed to perfection, his shoes gleaming. Mama wore a cream-colored dress, her hat a marvel of intricate lace and feathers, framing her face like a halo. David and I were in our best suits, feeling the unfamiliar stiffness of the fabric, the tight knot of the ties. Tamika looked stunning in a deep blue dress, her hair pulled back elegantly. Even Darius, usually prone to scuffs and wrinkles, was immaculate, though he still couldn't resist a quick, nervous fidget with his tie. Baby Keisha, in her own little Sunday best, cooed happily, oblivious to the solemnity but soaking in the collective joy.

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The walk to church was a procession. The neighborhood was quiet, still shaking off the sleep of the weekend, but people were starting to emerge, dressed in their own Sunday finest, heading to their own houses of worship. We greeted neighbors, our voices a little softer, our smiles a little wider. The usual street sounds – the distant clang of a garbage truck, the faint thrum of a lawnmower – seemed muted, respectful. The air was thick with the scent of freshly cut grass, of blooming roses climbing trellises, and the distinct, potent aroma of church perfume and pomade already clinging to the air, carried on the breeze from other churchgoers.

When we arrived at True Vine, the parking lot was already overflowing. Cars lined the street, gleaming in the morning sun. The church itself was packed, buzzing with a vibrant, anticipatory hum. Family had come from all over, from the old neighborhood on the west side, from downriver, from as far as Ohio – aunties with their magnificent hats, adorned with ribbons and flowers that seemed to defy gravity; uncles in their crisp, starched suits, their voices rumbling with greetings; cousins, some I hadn't seen in years, their faces alight with smiles. They packed the pews the way they used to pack our two-family flat on holidays, a warm, boisterous, loving multitude. The air inside was thick with the mingled scents of various perfumes, hairspray, and the warm, woody smell of old polished pews.

Grandma Lois sat in the very front row, a small, dignified figure, her silver hair pulled back in a neat bun. Her hands were folded in her lap, her eyes closed, her lips moving in a silent prayer that no one could hear but everyone could feel. It was a prayer that wrapped around the entire sanctuary, a blanket of ancestral faith, an echo of generations of hope and struggle and triumph. Her presence was a grounding force, a deep root connecting us to the past, to the enduring strength of our lineage.

The service began with an intensity that transcended the usual Sunday morning rhythm. The choir, dressed in their flowing robes, sang with a fervent passion, their voices blending into a powerful wave of sound that washed over us, preparing our spirits. The organist, Brother Thomas, a wizened man with nimble fingers, made the pipes sing, a deep, foundational rumble that vibrated through the floorboards and up into my very bones. It wasn't just music; it was a spiritual language, a direct line to the divine, speaking to parts of me that words couldn't reach. The brass section, usually reserved for special occasions, joined in, a trombone wailing with a bluesy, soulful cry that spoke of both sorrow and redemption.

Pastor Davis preached a sermon that morning about new beginnings, about leaving the old self behind and stepping into the light of God's grace. His voice, usually booming, was tempered with a gentle urgency, a plea for commitment. He spoke of the Jordan River, of the cleansing power of water, of the sacred covenant we were about to enter. The words resonated with the stirring in my chest, confirming everything I'd felt that Wednesday night.

Then came the moment. The choir hushed. The organ played a soft, sustained chord, a solemn underpinning. The baptismal pool, usually hidden behind a velvet curtain, was revealed, a shimmering expanse of clear, cool water at the front of the sanctuary, bathed in the soft glow of spotlights. It looked deeper than I'd imagined, almost like a small, tranquil pond.

One by one, my siblings and I were called forward. David went first, his stride purposeful, though I caught a flicker of nervousness in his eyes as he approached the water. He emerged, dripping but beaming, a new light in his usually serious face. Then Tamika, her initial solemnity giving way to an almost giddy joy as she rose from the water, her blue dress clinging wetly, but her spirit soaring. Darius, despite his earlier bravado, went in with a visible gulp, his eyes squeezed shut, but he came up sputtering, a wide, relieved grin splitting his face, the last vestiges of his shaking hands gone, replaced by a steady calm.

When it was Chris's turn, my turn, I walked to the edge of the baptismal pool. The cool, damp air rising from the water kissed my skin, raising goosebumps. I stood there, poised on the brink of this profound transformation, and looked out at the congregation. It was a sea of faces, a tapestry of love and faith.

I saw my mother, her face streaked with tears, not of sorrow but of profound, overflowing joy. Her lips were moving, whispering prayers I couldn't hear but could feel, a lifetime of hopes finally realized. I saw my father, his jaw tight, not in anger, but in a powerful, contained emotion, his eyes shining with a pride so deep it seemed to well up from the very bedrock of his soul. He gave a slight nod, a silent affirmation that spoke volumes. And there was my brother, David, already baptized, dripping wet, his suit plastered to him, grinning at me from the side, a look of shared victory and brotherhood in his eyes. He raised a hand, a silent cheer.

The pastor, Reverend Davis, a man whose hands had guided countless souls through these waters, placed a firm, reassuring hand on my back. His touch was warm, steady, a conduit of spiritual strength. His voice, clear and resonant, cut through the quiet hum of the congregation. "Do you accept Jesus Christ as

your Lord and Savior?"

"Yes," I answered, my voice surprisingly strong, clear, unwavering. It was the truest word I had ever spoken.

"Then I baptize you, my son," he declared, his voice ringing with authority and love, "in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit."

And then, he gently, firmly, lowered me back into the water.

The water closed over my head with a soft, whooshing sound, a sudden rush of cold that stole my breath. For one second — maybe less, maybe an eternity — the world went silent. Utterly, profoundly silent. No music. No voices. No murmurs from the congregation, no squeak of the pews, no distant rumble from the block, no whisper of the blessing. Just stillness. Just peace. It wasn't an empty silence; it was a silence full of God, a quiet so deep it felt like the very beginning of everything, a pure, unblemished void where only the divine resided. I felt weightless, suspended between two worlds, the old and the new. It was a moment out of time, a timeless instant of pure being.

And then, with a gentle lift, I rose.

The world rushed back in, not⁹⁶ with a jarring clash, but with a magnificent, jubilant explosion of sound and light. The congregation erupted. Hands clapped, a thunderous rhythm. Voices shouted praises, a glorious chorus of "Hallelujah!" and "Amen!" The organ, which had been silent, burst forth with a triumphant, soaring chord, filling the sanctuary with a joyous, earth-shaking melody. And I stood in the water, water running down my face, mingling with the last vestiges of Mama's tears, and felt something I'd never felt before — not just happiness, not just relief, but something deeper, something profoundly transformative. It was a sense of belonging, a clarity of purpose, a grounding that settled into my bones like a promise whispered from eternity. It was the feeling of being truly, irrevocably right.

I am not the same person I was thirty seconds ago. The thought wasn't a whisper in my mind; it was a conviction that vibrated through every cell, every fiber of my being. The old me, with all his young doubts and uncertainties, had been left in the depths. The new me, still young, still learning, but now anchored by an unshakable faith, stood renewed.

It was more than a ceremony. It was a public declaration of faith, a sacred covenant, and a profound commitment to continue walking with God, to let His light guide me no matter what challenges life might bring, no matter how loud the world outside or how quiet the Spirit might seem. It was the moment I claimed my place in the lineage of faith, joining the generations of believers who had come before me, whose prayers and hymns and struggles had paved the way.

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After the baptism, the joy continued to ripple through the church. As I stepped out of the pool, wrapped in a fluffy white towel by one of the deaconesses, the warmth of human touch and the smell of fresh linen were a comforting embrace. My skin still tingled from the cold water, but an inner warmth radiated through me. Church members, their faces beaming, pressed in, offering hugs and words of blessing, their hands patting my back, their voices a symphony of congratulations.

Then, Mama, her face still glistening with tears of joy, pulled all five of us siblings — David, Tamika, Darius, Keisha (who was now wide awake and curious, trying to grab at Mama's hat) and me — into a hug so tight, so fierce, it felt like she was trying to press us back into her very being. The scent of her perfume, mixed with the dampness of our clothes, was the smell of pure, unadulterated love. Baby Keisha, caught in the squeeze, let out a delighted squeal, a tiny, joyful counterpoint to the profound emotion of the moment. We were one, tangled together, a living testament to faith and family.

My father stood behind us, a sturdy anchor in the swirling sea of emotions. He didn't join the embrace, but his presence was a tangible force. He placed one hand on each of his sons' shoulders, David's and mine, his grip firm and steady. He said nothing. He didn't need to. His eyes, still shining, spoke volumes. They spoke of the prayers he had offered, the lessons he had taught, the quiet example he had set. They spoke of a legacy passed on, a hope renewed, a promise fulfilled. They said, I see you. I am proud. And now, you walk. And I knew, in that moment, that I was ready to walk.

The Choir

After being dipped in that cool, cleansing water, emerging from the baptistery with the scent of sacred oils and the weight of a new promise settled firm on my shoulders, life in the church transformed for me and my siblings. It wasn't just a place we went on Sundays because Mama and Daddy said so anymore; it was like a second skin, a living, breathing extension of our home on the east side. We were in it, we were of it. The feeling was profound, a deep hum beneath the surface of our days, connecting us to something ancient and ever-new. We became volunteers, not out of obligation, but with a fierce, joyful eagerness that surprised even ourselves.

Every Tuesday evening, after school let out and the Detroit sun began its slow descent, painting the brick of the two-family flats in hues of tired orange, you could find us scrambling through the back doors of Greater Mount Zion. The air inside always held that distinct church smell – a potent blend of lemon polish, old hymnals, and the lingering sweetness of the communion grape juice from Sunday. Our first job was often setting up chairs in the fellowship hall for Bible study. We'd drag the metal folding chairs from the storage closet, their legs scraping a mournful tune across the linoleum, and arrange them in neat, expectant rows. I learned to balance three chairs on each arm, my scrawny childhood muscles straining, while my sister, Maya, with her quick, precise movements, would snap them open with a practiced flick of her wrist. My younger brother, David, ever the comedian, would inevitably get his fingers pinched and let out a dramatic yelp, only to be shushed by Maya, whose patience wore thin faster than a summer dress. It was more than just setting up chairs; it was preparing the space, making it ready for the Word to be shared, for fellowship to blossom. We were building the foundation, piece by humble piece.

Then came the bulletins, crisp and smelling faintly of fresh ink from the church's temperamental duplicator. We'd fold them with meticulous care, ensuring each crease was sharp, each page aligned. Inside, the order of service, the prayer requests, the upcoming events – a tiny map of our week, our community's heartbeat. Sometimes, Mama would be in the kitchen already, her hands moving with a practiced grace as she chopped onions for a soup or stirred a pot of greens that would simmer all night, filling the church with an aroma that promised warmth and sustenance. The kitchen was a symphony of clatter and steam, the low murmur of adult voices, and the occasional burst of laughter. We'd help where we could, washing plastic cups, stacking paper plates, feeling the cool rush of water over our hands, the textured scrub of a sponge against a stainless steel sink. It wasn't glamorous work, but it was our work, a quiet offering. Each task, no matter how small, felt like a stitch in the fabric of the church, and by extension, in the fabric of our lives.

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But for all the satisfaction of those quiet, dutiful tasks, it was the junior choir that truly snagged our spirits, wrapping its melodic tendrils around our young hearts and pulling us into its vibrant core. I remember the first time I really saw them, not just heard them as background noise during service. It was during a special youth Sunday, and they were lined up on the steps of the pulpit, a colorful assembly of bright robes – crimson and gold, shimmering under the sanctuary lights. Sister Eleanor, the choir director, a woman with a smile as wide and welcoming as a sunrise and a voice that could both soothe a crying baby and rouse a sleeping congregation, stood before them, conducting with an almost balletic grace.

They sang "Jesus Loves Me," but not the simple, nursery-rhyme version we knew. This was a gospel arrangement, with a lilting tempo and harmonies that swirled and intertwined like ribbons in the wind. The way their young voices, a mix of trebles and nascent altos, swelled and then softened, the way they swayed in unison, their faces alight with an almost incandescent joy – it was mesmerizing. It wasn't just singing; it was storytelling, testimony, prayer all rolled into one. I watched, transfixed, feeling a strange pull in my chest, a yearning I hadn't known I possessed. Maya nudged me, her eyes wide, and even little David, usually fidgeting, was still, his gaze fixed on the vibrant scene. Later that day, after fried chicken and macaroni and cheese had been devoured back home, Maya declared, "I'm joining the choir." And without a moment's hesitation, I said, "Me too." It felt like a calling, a whisper from the very air around

us.

From that moment on, our lives gained a new, resonant rhythm. Week after week, our Saturday mornings were dedicated to rehearsals. We'd walk the four blocks to church, the air often cool and crisp, carrying the promise of autumn or the first tentative breath of spring, our chatter fading as we neared the old brick building. The fellowship hall, usually host to potlucks and committee meetings, transformed into our sacred practice space. It smelled different then, not of lemon polish, but of dusty hymnals and the faint, metallic tang of Sister Eleanor's old upright piano.

Sister Eleanor was a force of nature, a woman whose every movement was imbued with a spiritual purpose. Her fingers, gnarled with age and years of playing, danced across the piano keys, coaxing melodies that seemed to leap from the wood and fill the room. She taught us not just the notes, but the meaning behind them. "Children," she'd say, her voice rich and warm like molasses, "we ain't just makin' noise. We makin' a joyful noise unto the Lord. And joy ain't always loud, sometimes it's a whisper, sometimes it's a moan. You gotta feel it in your bones, let it rise from your belly, through your heart, and out your mouth."

She drilled us on our parts, her ¹⁰⁵patience a deep well, though she wasn't above a sharp clap of her hands or a gentle, "Now, Brother Chris, you soundin' like a frog caught in a rain barrel. Let's try that high note again, from the diaphragm, son, from the diaphragm!" She taught us breath control, posture, how to articulate each word so that the message of the song was clear, unwavering. We learned to read sheet music, deciphering the dots and lines like a secret code. Sometimes, after an hour of scales and vocal exercises, our throats would ache, but the satisfaction of finally hitting a difficult harmony, of hearing our individual voices merge into a single, beautiful current, was a reward sweeter than any candy.

We practiced our swaying, learning to move as one, a gentle rock that underscored the rhythm. We learned to clap on the off-beat, a syncopated snap that added zest to the gospel numbers. And we learned to lift our hands, not just in a performative gesture, but as an outpouring of genuine worship, a physical manifestation of the spirit rising within us. These rehearsals weren't just about learning songs; they were about learning discipline, collaboration, and how to pour our entire being into an offering of praise.

Sunday services became the culmination, the grand unveiling of our week's work. Dressed in our robes, we'd gather in the small room off the side of the sanctuary, the air thick with nervous energy and the sweet, cloying scent of church perfume from the usher board ladies. My heart would pound like a drum against my ribs as we waited for our cue. Then, the grand processional, the slow, deliberate march down the aisle, the rustle of our robes, the soft murmur of the congregation. The sanctuary, usually a place of quiet reverence, seemed to hold its breath as we ascended the steps to the pulpit. The organ would swell, Brother Thomas's fingers dancing across the keys, a prelude of majesty and anticipation. And then, Sister Eleanor's nod, her eyes

twinkling, and we would begin.

The junior choir wasn't large, never more than maybe fifteen kids on a good Sunday, a handful of us scattered across the various age groups, from the littlest ones who barely knew their parts to the almost-teenagers whose voices were starting to deepen and crack. But what we lacked in sheer numbers, we made up for in an overflowing, undeniable heart. We were small, but mighty.

When we sang traditional hymns, like "Amazing Grace" or "How Great Thou Art," we sang them with the solemnity of a cathedral choir, our young voices reaching for a gravitas that belied our years. Our faces would take on a serious, almost reverent cast, our eyes closed as we poured our understanding of suffering and salvation into each drawn-out note. The sanctuary would grow quiet, the usual rustle of bulletins and shifting bodies stilled, as if the very air was listening. You could feel the weight of generations of worship in those ancient melodies, and we tried to honor that legacy with every breath.

But when we launched into gospel songs – "Oh Happy Day," "Total Praise," or one of Sister Eleanor's rousing arrangements of a familiar spiritual – the energy shifted, crackling like electricity. It was the energy of a full-blown concert, a revival tent meeting, a joyful explosion of sound and movement. We swayed, our crimson robes flowing like liquid fire, our feet tapping an irresistible rhythm. We clapped our hands, sharp and precise, punctuating the beats, and we lifted them high, reaching towards the ornate ceiling, towards the unseen. Our faces would be transformed, lit up with unadulterated joy, sweat beading on our foreheads from the sheer effort and exhilaration.

And the congregation, Lord, the congregation responded! They wouldn't just listen; they would participate. From the pews, you'd hear a chorus of "Amen!" and "Hallelujah!" A sister in a wide-brimmed hat might begin to wave her hand, slowly at first, then with increasing fervor. A brother, usually stoic, would nod his head, a beatific smile spreading across his face. And then came the shouts, the cries of encouragement that fueled our fire: "Sing, children! Sing!" "Yes, Lord!" "Bless these babies!" It was a call and response, a sacred dialogue between the singers and the hearers, a shared spiritual experience that transcended the physical space. In those moments, we weren't just kids singing in church; we were conduits, messengers, vessels of a divine melody.

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I loved every single second of it, every single note. I loved the way our voices sounded when they blended together, not like separate people singing the same song, but like one voice made of many. It was a strange alchemy, individual timbres dissolving into a rich, unified chord, a sonic tapestry woven from threads of innocence and burgeoning understanding. It wasn't just harmony; it was unity, a living example of what we were taught about the body of Christ. My alto part might be steady and grounding, Maya's soprano clear and soaring, David's treble a bright, innocent sparkle, but together, we were something more, something profoundly beautiful and complete.

I loved the way the music built, layer upon layer, like the rising sun painting the Detroit sky. First, the simple melody, then the bass line rumbling beneath, providing a sturdy foundation. Then the alto, wrapping around the melody like a comforting embrace, and finally, the sopranos, soaring above it all, adding brilliance and light. Each voice, each part, essential and distinct, yet utterly dependent on the others. It would swell, rising in intensity, filling the sanctuary like light fills a room at sunrise, chasing away the shadows, illuminating every corner, every soul. It wasn't just sound; it was a physical sensation, a vibration that hummed in my chest, tickled my ears, and resonated deep within my spirit. It felt like warmth, like comfort, like pure, unadulterated hope.

More than anything, I loved the way singing made me feel connected. Connected to the other kids in the choir, my brothers and sisters in song, sharing nervous glances before a big note, exchanging triumphant smiles after a particularly strong finish. Connected to the congregation, their faces upturned, some weeping, some shouting, all of them receiving the gift we offered. Their tears were our benediction, their shouts our encouragement. And, most profoundly, I felt connected to something I was beginning to understand was bigger than all of us. It was the Spirit, the Holy Ghost, the very breath of God moving through us, shaping the air into sound, into praise, into an undeniable presence. It was in those moments, standing on the pulpit, my voice blending with others, the music swelling around me, that my faith moved from a concept to an experience, from words in a book to a living, breathing reality. It was a tangible connection to the divine, a spiritual language spoken through melody and rhythm.



As time passed, the bonds forged in the heat of rehearsals and the joy of performance began to stretch beyond the four walls of Greater Mount Zion. The church youth grew closer to Chris's family, and our little two-family flat on the east side, with its perpetually humming refrigerator and the faint scent of Mama's cooking always lingering, became a hub. What began as simple friendships – shared laughs, homework help, comparing notes on the latest Motown hits playing on the radio – soon became something much deeper, something akin to kinship.

There was Michael, quiet and observant, whose parents worked two jobs and were rarely home. He'd often tag along with David and me after rehearsal, ostensibly to "study," but mostly to just be in the warmth of our home. And Sarah, whose family had just moved to Detroit from Alabama, carrying with them the soft cadences of the South and a yearning for community. Then there was Marcus, a few years older than me, already grappling with the temptations of the streets that coiled just beyond the reach of our block. These weren't just kids we sang with; they were becoming our chosen family.

Our parents, Mama and Daddy, with their boundless hearts and unwavering faith, welcomed these young people with the same warmth they showed their own children. Our dining table, usually crowded with just the five of us, suddenly expanded, extra chairs pulled up, extra plates piled high with food. Sunday dinner, already a feast for the senses, became even more vibrant. The aroma of Mama's collard greens, slow-cooked with smoked turkey, mingling with the crispy scent of fried chicken, the rich creaminess of her baked macaroni and cheese, and the sweet, buttery perfume of her cornbread. The kitchen would be a bustling hive of activity, laughter and conversation spilling over, the clatter of forks against plates a joyful symphony.

"You kids eat up now," Mama would say, her eyes twinkling, "there's plenty more where that came from." And there always was. It wasn't just the food; it was the atmosphere. It was a safe harbor, a place where you could shed the burdens of the week, where you were seen, heard, and cherished.

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Beyond the meals, there was the wisdom, offered not as stern lectures, but as gentle guidance, as everyday counsel. Daddy, usually a man of few words, would sit on the porch swing in the evenings, watching the world go by, the breeze carrying the distant strains of a Temptations song from a neighbor's open window. He'd offer a quiet word to Marcus, who might be wrestling with a tough decision at school, or a reassuring nod to Sarah, who was feeling homesick. "Son," he might say, his voice low and steady, "the street got many voices, but only one speak truth. You gotta learn to listen for that one." Mama, with her soft hands and knowing eyes, would listen patiently to Michael's worries about his grades, or Maya's teenage dramas, offering comfort and perspective. "God don't give you no burden you can't carry, baby," she'd often say, her hand resting gently on a shoulder, "but He do expect you to use your head and your heart to figure it out."

It was a love without conditions, a love that saw beyond mistakes, beyond imperfections, and embraced the whole person. They didn't just preach compassion; they lived it. They didn't just talk about community; they built it, right there in our living room, around our kitchen table, on our front porch. They embodied the teachings of the church in every fiber of their being, and they extended that grace freely to every young soul who walked through our door.

The youth, in turn, admired the warmth and guidance they received from Chris's mother and father with an almost reverent respect. They saw in Mama's steadfast strength and Daddy's quiet dignity a reflection of what they yearned for in their own lives. They saw a family rooted in love, faith, and mutual respect, a beacon in a world that often felt chaotic and uncertain. They gravitated towards it, like moths to a flame, finding solace and stability in our humble home.

I remember the first time it happened. We were all piled into the living room, listening to Marvin Gaye on the stereo, the windows open to let in the humid Detroit air. Sarah had just finished telling Mama about a spat with her own mother, tears welling in her eyes. Mama had listened, offered a hug, and a plate of warm peach cobbler. As Sarah got up to leave, her voice was soft, hesitant, "Thank you, Mom," she said, almost a whisper, her eyes meeting Mama's. Mama just smiled, a gentle, understanding smile, and squeezed Sarah's hand. It wasn't forced, it wasn't planned; it just was.

After that, it became a natural thing. Michael, shyly at first, then with growing confidence, would call my father "Pop" when he needed advice or just a word of encouragement. Marcus, whose own father was absent, started referring to Daddy as "Pop" with a reverence that made my chest swell with a strange mix of pride and a flicker of something close to jealousy, quickly replaced by understanding. It was a profound honor, a recognition of their parental spirit, a testament to the fact that love knows no biological boundaries. My parents had become surrogate parents, spiritual anchors for a generation of young people navigating the choppy waters of adolescence in the city. And I, as their son, felt the immense weight and blessing of that, understanding that their love was not diminished by being shared, but multiplied.

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The church no longer felt like just a place of worship, a building with stained-glass windows and a steeple reaching towards the sky. It felt like family. The hymns we sang weren't just songs; they were our family anthems, echoing the triumphs and tribulations of our shared journey. The sermons weren't just lessons; they were conversations, guiding principles for our collective path. The people in the pews weren't just congregants; they were aunts, uncles, cousins, brothers and sisters, bound not just by blood, but by a deeper, more sacred covenant. We were all woven into the same tapestry, threads of different colors and textures, but together, forming a whole, vibrant and resilient. This community, nurtured by faith and sustained by love, became the bedrock of my childhood, shaping my understanding of hope, connection, and the enduring power of a soulful melody.

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Now Direct

The fluorescent lights of the fellowship hall hummed above us, casting a pale, unforgiving glow on the scuffed linoleum floor and the mismatched folding chairs. This was where the junior choir gathered every Tuesday and Thursday evening, a space usually reserved for potlucks and bake sales, now transformed into a crucible of sound. I loved it here, even with the faint, lingering smell of collard greens and sweet potato pie clinging to the air from Sunday dinner, mingling with the sharper tang of wood polish and the sweet, heavy perfume of Sister Denise.

Sister Denise. Her name alone brought a wave of warmth to my chest. She was one of our youth overseers, a woman built like a sturdy oak, with a laugh that started low in her belly and blossomed into a joyous peal, and eyes that saw straight through any pretense. She'd been guiding the junior choir for twelve years, a whole lifetime in my young eyes. She'd seen generations of us Detroit kids come through these doors, hands raised in praise, hearts full of rhythm. Some, like a few older cousins, burned bright and fast, their voices soaring for a season before the lure of the streets or the quiet pull of indifference drew them away. Others drifted, like leaves caught in an autumn wind, eventually settling into the quiet pews, their singing voices softened to a murmur. But some, a precious few, stayed. And Sister Denise, with the wisdom of a seasoned gardener, knew how to spot the seedlings that held the promise of deep roots.

She said I was different. I never knew exactly what she meant back then, not in so many words. I just loved the music. Loved the way the harmonies twisted and tangled, then unwound into something beautiful and true. Loved the way a song could lift you, right out of your skin, right out of the worries of the block, and carry you somewhere closer to the heavens. But Sister Denise, she saw past the simple love. She saw not only my passion for music, a fire she recognized from her own youth, but also the leadership qualities quietly growing inside me, like a sturdy vine seeking sunlight.

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She'd watch me, sometimes from the worn-out armchair in the corner where she'd sit with her Bible open, sometimes from the piano bench, her fingers stilled on the keys as she observed. She noticed the small things. The way I'd lean over to a younger alto, barely ten years old, her voice a little shaky, and whisper the next note, guiding her gently into the harmony. It wasn't about showing off; it was about the music needing to be whole, needing to be right. She saw the way I'd stand a little taller, my chest puffed out just a hair, when the choir, after countless repetitions, finally locked into a perfect chord, the sound resonating through the room, making the very air vibrate. It was a physical response, an almost involuntary alignment with the beauty we were creating together.

But most of all, she saw the way I listened. Truly listened. Not just to the notes themselves, to whether a soprano was flat or a tenor was sharp, but to the spaces between them. To the breath before the attack, the lingering echo after the cutoff. To the silence that held the music, cradling it like a mother holds her child. She told my Mama once, over a plate of Sunday dinner, that I listened like an old soul, like someone who understood that the real message often lay not in what was said, but in the hush that surrounded it. She'd seen that kind of listening in the old saints, in the deacons who offered prayers that felt like sermons, in the bluesmen who wrung every drop of emotion from a single bent note.

She watched me for weeks, her gaze a steady, quiet beam. She prayed about it, I knew she did. Sister Denise didn't make a move without taking it to the Lord first. She'd tell us often, "Before you step, you kneel. Before you speak, you listen to His whisper." I imagined her on her knees in her own living room, the Detroit dusk filtering through the lace curtains, asking for guidance. Asking if this quiet boy from the east side, with his eager heart and his nimble fingers on the trombone, was ready for something more. Ready to step out of the shadows and into the light of his own calling. And then, one humid evening in late summer, with the city's breath thick and warm outside, she made her move.

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The fellowship hall was abuzz that evening. It was junior choir rehearsal, and the air was thick with the comfortable noise of young people being young. A cacophony of adolescent energy, still raw and unrefined, but full of life. A couple of girls in the alto section were giggling about a boy from the senior choir, their whispers like rustling leaves. A few tenors were trying to imitate the bass line from a Motown classic, their voices cracking in comical attempts. Somewhere in the back, a trumpet player was attempting a shaky rendition of "Amazing Grace," while my brother, always the steady anchor, was already behind his drum kit, tapping out a gentle, intricate rhythm on the snare, a soft shhh-tup, shhh-tup that was like the heartbeat of the room.

I was in my usual spot, second row, wedged between two altos whose voices, though sweet, often lacked the conviction I yearned for. My trombone, gleaming brass, rested in its case at my feet. I was humming along to the melody we'd been practicing, feeling the notes vibrate in my own chest, trying to imagine how they'd sound once we added the full weight of the organ and the power of the senior choir. I was content, lost in the pure, unadulterated joy of the music.

Then a shadow fell over me. I looked up. It was Sister Denise.

She didn't say anything at first. She just stood there, her presence a quiet force, her Sunday hat, a magnificent concoction of straw and silk flowers, replaced by a simple headscarf tonight. She smiled — that warm, knowing smile that church mothers have perfected over centuries, a smile that carried the weight of generations, of blessings offered and burdens shared. It was a smile that promised understanding, but also demanded attention. Then, without a word, she gently reached down and took my hand. Her skin felt cool and slightly calloused, the skin of a woman who had worked hard, prayed harder, and held many hands in comfort and guidance.

My mind raced. "Ma'am?" I asked, my voice barely a squeak. What did she want? Had I done something wrong? Forgotten a lyric? Played a wrong note on the trombone last Sunday? My heart gave a little flutter of anxiety, the kind you get when an elder looks at you with that particular intensity.

She didn't answer. Her grip on my hand was firm but tender. She didn't pull, but led. She drew me from my secure spot in the second row, a place I'd come to know intimately, where the backs of the heads in front of me provided a comforting anonymity. I was always there, tucked between two altos, slightly behind my brother, whose drum kit was his own

kingdom. To be pulled from that spot, from that familiar comfort, was disorienting.

She led me forward, past the curious faces of my peers, past the rows of music stands, past the polished wood of the piano. Every step felt like walking a tightrope. My legs felt suddenly heavy, then too light. The room, which had been a symphony of youthful chatter and scattered instrument sounds, began to quiet. Not all at once, not with a sudden, jarring halt, but in a wave, like someone had slowly, deliberately turned down the volume on an old stereo. First, the giggling stopped, then the off-key humming, then the tap-tap-tap of a pen against a music folder. The air grew thick with unspoken questions. Kids stopped talking. Music folders lowered. Heads turned.

All eyes, a constellation of curious, questioning, and slightly amused gazes, turned to me. Chris. Just Chris. Standing at the front of the choir, exposed, vulnerable, with my heart hammering so loud in my chest I was sure everyone could hear it, a drum solo of pure panic. The fluorescent lights felt hotter now, brighter, making my palms sweat.

Sister Denise stood beside me for a moment, her presence a steadying anchor in the swirling chaos of my nerves. The silence stretched, a vast, echoing space that swallowed all sound. Then, I felt the gentle weight of her hand on my shoulder. It was a touch that carried reassurance, yes, but also a profound expectation. I looked up at her, my eyes wide, pleading for an explanation.

She simply smiled again, a slow, deep smile that reached her eyes, crinkling the corners. And then she said four words, simple words, spoken with the quiet certainty of a prophet, words that landed in the suddenly vast silence of the room and would change the trajectory of my life forever:

"Now direct the choir."

I froze. My lungs forgot how to breathe. My mind, usually buzzing with melodies and rhythms, went utterly blank. All I could feel was the blood rushing in my ears, a roar louder than any drum solo.

I looked at Sister Denise. Her smile hadn't wavered. She nodded, a small, encouraging dip of her head that dared me to defy her.

I turned my gaze to the choir. Fifteen faces stared back at me. Some were curious, their eyebrows raised in questioning arcs. Some were amused, a few snickers barely suppressed. And some, the older ones, the ones who had been in choir longer than me, were openly skeptical, their eyes saying, Who does this little boy think he is? Tamika, my sister, stood in the alto section, her usual spot, her dark eyes narrowed. She raised one perfectly sculpted eyebrow, a silent message passing between us that said, clearer than any shout, You better not mess this up, Chris. Our family name is on the line. It was the sisterly threat that disguised a fierce loyalty.

Then my eyes found his. My brother. He was behind his drum kit, his sticks resting on the snare, a picture of calm amidst my internal storm. A slow, easy grin spread across his face, a grin that crinkled his eyes and spoke volumes. Don't worry, little brother, that grin said. I got you. Always. It was the unspoken promise of a lifetime, the certainty of a shared path, the comfort of knowing that no matter how high I stumbled, he'd be there to catch me. His presence, solid and unwavering, was a balm to my raw nerves.

I turned back to the choir, my heart still hammering, a frantic rhythm against my ribs. I felt my hands trembling, a tremor that started in my fingertips and spread up my arms. I felt my breath catch in my throat, a knot of fear and apprehension. Every doubt I'd ever had about myself, every quiet insecurity I'd nurtured in the solitary moments of childhood, rushed to the surface like air bubbles in murky water.

I'm not a director, a small, terrified voice whispered inside me. I'm just a kid. I sing in the second row. I play trombone. I'm nobody special. I'm just Chris, from the east side, whose Mama makes the best collard greens and whose Daddy works two jobs to keep the lights on. The weight of expectation, the sudden, blinding spotlight, felt unbearable. I was just a boy, small in the grand scheme of Detroit, small in the vastness of the church, small against the power of the music.

But then — underneath the doubt, underneath the fear, underneath the hammering of my heart — I heard it. That frequency. That hum. It wasn't a sound heard with my ears, not exactly. It was a vibration felt deep in my bones, a resonant chord struck in the very core of my being. It was the sound that lived between the block and the blessing, between the music and the silence, between who I was and who I was becoming. It was the whisper of the ancestors, the heartbeat of Motown, the spirit of every gospel chord ever struck in a Detroit church. It was the feeling of Mama's hands kneading dough, of Daddy's quiet prayers before he left for work, of the collective hopes and dreams of our community. It was the voice of God, not thundering from the heavens, but gently murmuring in the quiet space just behind my fear. It was the language of grace, woven into the very fabric of my existence. And in that moment, the hum became a directive, clearer than Sister Denise's words. It told me to breathe. To trust. To simply

be.

Slowly, almost painfully, I lifted my arms. They felt heavy, like they were made of lead, resistant to my will. My movements were timid and unsure, my hands shaking visibly, betraying the raw nerves that still pulsed through me. I tried to remember the conductor from the televised gospel concerts, the way his hands moved with such elegant authority, shaping the air as if it were clay. But my hands were clumsy, my timing off, like a broken clock. I gave a downbeat that came half a second too late, a hesitant, almost apologetic gesture.

The choir stumbled. It was a collective gasp of sound, a hesitant, off-kilter entrance into the first measure, like runners tripping over a starting line, their individual voices clashing, a cacophony of confusion. A few kids exchanged bewildered glances. My face burned with shame. I knew it, the little voice of doubt screamed. You can't do this.

But then, from behind the drums, I¹²⁵ heard him. My brother. He caught it. He always did. It was instinct, honed over years of sharing a bedroom, sharing secrets under the covers, sharing a love for rhythm that was as fundamental as breathing. He didn't miss a beat, but his sticks, instead of driving forward, subtly adjusted. He slowed the tempo, just a hair, his kick drum laying down a deeper, steadier pulse. His hi-hat softened, becoming a gentle, unwavering whisper that said, It's okay. Take your time. I got you. He steadied the groove, gave me a solid, unshakeable foundation to stand on, a rhythmic bedrock in the midst of my crumbling confidence. It was love, pure and unconditional, expressed through the language we both understood best: music. It was everything our bond had been building toward since those nights in our two-family flat on the east side, tapping rhythms on upturned pots and pans in the kitchen, inventing melodies on toy pianos, sharing headphones to listen to Motown legends and gospel greats. He wasn't just playing; he was holding me up, his music a safety net woven just for me.

I took a deep, shuddering breath, the air filling my lungs with the lingering scents of church and childhood. I squeezed my eyes shut for a microsecond, the hum vibrating again, louder this time, a quiet roar of affirmation. I reset. I wiped my clammy palms on my choir robe, straightened my shoulders, and looked at the choir again, my gaze finding my brother's first, a silent promise exchanged. I gave the downbeat again. This time, it was firmer, clearer, born not just of my will, but of that guiding hum, of my brother's steady rhythm. And this time, the choir responded.

The sopranos came in clean, their voices clear as crystal, hitting the high notes with a newfound confidence. The altos held their line, their harmonies rich and warm, a velvet cushion beneath the melody. The tenors found their note, their sound adding a soulful depth, a masculine strength that anchored the whole. And the sound — that glorious, unified, heaven-reaching sound — rose up around me like water, like light, like grace itself. It washed over me, through me, a baptism of pure, unadulterated musical power. The air in the fellowship hall thrummed, alive with the vibrations. It felt like the very walls were breathing with us, exhaling praise.

I started guiding the rhythm with growing confidence, my initial tremor replaced by a newfound fluidity. My hands, once clumsy, now moved with an intuitive grace, shaping the sound, pulling it forth, guiding it with a joy I had never experienced before. It was a joy different from singing a perfect harmony, different from nailing a difficult passage on my trombone, different from anything I'd known. This was a joy of creation, of orchestration, of being a conduit for something larger than myself. It was the joy of watching individual voices weave into a tapestry, of seeing the music come alive through my hands, through our collective breath.

This was what I was made for. I felt it in my arms, a tingling energy that flowed from my fingertips. I felt it in my chest, a profound expansion, as if my heart had suddenly found its true home. I felt it in the tears that gathered in the corners of my eyes, hot and insistent, but didn't fall. I was conducting, yes — my hands shaping the air, my heart holding the beat — but I was also being conducted. Something larger was moving through me, using my hands to shape the sound, using my heart to hold the beat. It was the spirit of the music, the spirit of Detroit, the spirit of our faith, flowing through me, making me an instrument in a symphony far grander than I could ever orchestrate alone. It was

the hum, amplified, made manifest.

Standing nearby, a solid, reassuring presence, was my brother, faithfully playing alongside me. His eyes, usually dancing with mischief, were focused, his hands a blur of controlled motion on the drums. He watched me, his gaze steady, his rhythmic foundation unwavering. Our eyes met once during the song, a fleeting connection across the space, and in that look was everything. Every walk to school through the gritty Detroit mornings, the steam rising from the manholes. Every night falling asleep in our shared bedroom, the sounds of Mama and Daddy talking low in the next room, the faint scent of greens cooking lingering from dinner. Every scraped knee, every shared secret, every dream whispered into the darkness. We didn't need words. We never had. Our language was rhythm, our understanding woven into the very fabric of our being, a bond stronger than any chord. He was the anchor, and I, for this moment, was the sail.

Sister Denise stood at the side of the room, arms crossed, a quiet sentinel. The pale fluorescent light caught the wet sheen on her cheeks, tears running freely down her face, glistening like diamonds. But her face was not one of sorrow. It was a face radiant with pure, unadulterated joy. She was smiling, that deep, knowing smile, the smile of someone who had just watched a seed, carefully nurtured and patiently observed, finally become a tree, its branches reaching for the sky, its roots digging deep into the rich Detroit soil. She wasn't just seeing a boy direct a choir; she was seeing a prophecy fulfilled, a calling answered, a future

unfolding.

When the song ended, the final chord hung in the air, vibrating, shimmering, slowly fading into a profound silence. The room was silent for a beat. Then two. Then three. It wasn't the silence of confusion or awkwardness, but a silence of awe, of collective breath held, of a moment so potent it demanded reverence. The air was thick with the lingering resonance of the music, a spiritual afterglow.

And then, it erupted.

It started with a single clap, then two, then a wave of sound that swallowed the silence whole. Clapping, cheering, feet stomping a joyful rhythm on the linoleum floor. The room exploded with an energy that vibrated through the floorboards, through my very bones. The younger kids were jumping up and down, their faces alight with excitement. The skeptical older ones were now grinning, their earlier doubts replaced by genuine admiration. Tamika, my sister, usually so composed, was shouting from the back row, her voice ringing clear above the din, "That's my BROTHER! Y'all hear that? That's my BROTHER!" Her pride was a tangible thing, a warm embrace across the room.

My brother, caught up in the pure, unbridled joy, hit a celebratory drum fill that rattled the windows, a complex, joyful cascade of sound that felt like thunder and sunshine all at once. It was his way of saying, You did it, man. You really did it.

Through the chaos of celebration, Sister Denise walked over to me. Her steps were deliberate, measured, even amidst the jubilation. Her face, still streaked with tears, glowed with an almost otherworldly light. She reached out, taking my face in both her hands, her touch firm and warm, grounding me in the moment. I looked into her eyes, and saw not just pride, but a deep, knowing love, and a profound sense of confirmation.

"I knew it," she said, her voice thick with emotion, her words cutting through the lingering noise of the room, reaching me directly, intimately. "I knew it since the first day you walked in here, Chris. Since I saw that quiet fire in your eyes, since I heard you listen to the spaces between the notes. God put music in you, boy. He put it in your spirit, in your hands, in your very soul. Now you know why." And in that moment, standing there, my face in Sister Denise's hands, the joyful noise of the choir swelling around me, I finally understood. I wasn't just a kid who loved music. I was a vessel. And the harmonies of hope, the very song of God, had just found its director.

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The Harmony Unfolds

At such a young age, Chris had already experienced tremendous change. The kind of change that rips a sapling from its shallow soil and plants it deep, deep into new, rich earth, daring it to wither or to bloom. Looking back now, from the vantage point of a man who'd seen more seasons than he cared to count, I understand that those early shifts were not just events, but the very tectonic plates of my developing soul, shifting, grinding, and settling into a new landscape.

I remember the day we moved into the new home on the east side, a two-family flat just like the one we'd left, but this one felt different, smelled different. The old house had the faint, persistent aroma of my grandmother's fried chicken and the lingering sweetness of Daddy's pipe tobacco. This new one, when Mama and Daddy first unlocked the door, carried the ghost of the previous tenants – a whisper of lemon polish and something vaguely metallic, like old pennies. We were upstairs, above a quiet, older couple who kept to themselves, their muffled arguments and the scent of their Sunday pot roast drifting up through the floorboards like a secret language. Our flat, though, quickly took on the scent of our family: Mama's greens simmering on the stove, the sharp tang of Comet in the bathroom, the faint, sweet-and-sour perfume of Daddy's aftershave, and the undeniable, vibrant smell of six children living, laughing, and occasionally fighting under one roof. The streets themselves were a symphony I was still learning to decipher. The rumble of the DSR bus, the distant wail of a police siren, the rhythmic thump of car stereos blasting everything from George Clinton to Marvin Gaye, weaving a dense tapestry of sound that was uniquely Detroit.

I had started at a new school, too,¹³² just a few blocks away, and that transition felt like stepping onto a stage mid-performance, trying to find my cue. The hallways at Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. Elementary School smelled of stale gym socks, cheap floor wax, and the nervous sweat of a thousand children. My old school had been mostly Black and brown faces, familiar echoes of my own family. Here, the faces were still mostly Black, but the accents were different, the slang was new, and I felt like a stranger in a familiar land. There were no immediate connections, no old friends to lean on during dodgeball or to whisper jokes with during Mrs. Jenkins's droning history lessons. I spent those first weeks observing, a quiet sentinel, trying to map the social currents, understanding who held sway on the playground and who kept to the periphery, like me. It was a lonely kind of learning, but it taught me to read people, to listen more than I spoke, and to find strength in my own company until I could forge new bonds.

And then, the church. Oh, the church. We joined a new church, True Vine Missionary Baptist, a squat brick building with stained-glass windows depicting scenes from the Bible, the colors muted by decades of Detroit dust and sun. Our old church had been smaller, more intimate, with a choir loft that felt like home. True Vine was grander, the sanctuary soaring, the pews a deeper, richer mahogany. The first Sunday we walked in, the air itself seemed thicker, perfumed with the scent of lilies and old hymnals, a potent blend that spoke of reverence and history. Sister Bernice, the head usher, a woman whose smile could melt glaciers and whose stern gaze could silence a toddler mid-tantrum, greeted us at the door, her gloved hand gently guiding us to a row of empty pews near the front. The organ music, played by Brother Thomas, swelled and vibrated through the floorboards, a living, breathing thing that wrapped itself around me, a comforting balm to my unsettled spirit. It was a sound that

told me, without a single word, that I was exactly where I needed to be.

It wasn't long after, in that very sanctuary, that I publicly gave my life to God through baptism. I remember the cool, almost shocking embrace of the water in the baptismal pool, a sudden chill that quickly gave way to a profound warmth. The white robe felt heavy and unfamiliar against my skin, clinging slightly as I stepped down into the water, led by Pastor Jenkins, a man whose voice boomed like thunder and soothed like a lullaby. The whole church watched, a sea of faces, some tearful, some smiling, all offering their silent prayers. When Pastor Jenkins gently tilted me back, immersing me fully, the world went quiet for a sacred second. It was just me and the water, and a feeling like all the noise and fear and uncertainty of the past few months were being washed away, leaving behind a clean slate, a renewed promise. When I rose, gasping slightly, water streaming from my face, a cheer erupted, a collective sigh of relief and joy. I felt lighter, brighter, as if a great weight had been lifted, replaced by a buoyant hope.

In the weeks and months that followed, I formed new friendships that felt like family. There was Jamal, whose laugh was infectious and whose knowledge of rap lyrics was encyclopedic; Keisha, with her quick wit and even quicker smile; and Marcus, whose quiet intensity belied a deep kindness. We found each other in the church youth group, in the school hallways, on the basketball court at the park down the street. We shared secrets, dreams, and the occasional forbidden candy bar. They understood the unspoken rules of the block, the subtle shifts in the air when older kids passed by, the rhythm of life in our corner of Detroit. They became my anchor, my sounding board, my partners in mischief and in faith.

And then, the music. Oh, the music. I had joined the junior choir alongside my siblings. My sister, Denise, had a voice like pure sunshine, bright and clear, always finding the melody. My brother, Michael, with his booming baritone, held down the bass line with a confidence that belied his age. We stood together, shoulder to shoulder, our voices blending, becoming part of something larger than ourselves. It was a natural fit, a continuation of the harmonies we'd practiced around Mama's piano since we were toddlers. The choir director, Sister Johnson, a petite woman with hands that moved like a conductor's baton even when she was just talking, recognized something in me, something beyond just a decent voice. She saw the way I listened, the way I watched her, absorbing every nuance of her direction. She saw the way my eyes lit up when the notes coalesced into a perfect chord. And now — standing at the front of the choir stand each Sunday, arms raised, heart full — I had become the director of the junior choir. It had happened so fast, a whirlwind of unexpected blessings. One Sunday, Sister Johnson had fallen ill, and with no one else to lead, she'd pointed a shaky finger at me from her hospital bed over the phone, telling Mama, "Chris knows the spirit. He'll do." And I did. I stepped up, nervous as a newborn fawn, but the music itself seemed to guide my hands, to lift my voice, to command the fifteen young singers before me. It was terrifying and exhilarating, all at once.

For Chris, life finally seemed full of hope and promise. It wasn't just a fleeting feeling, like the scent of honeysuckle in the summer air that would soon fade. No, this was a deep, abiding certainty, like the foundation of our flat, solid and unyielding. The constant hum of Motown radio from our kitchen, the soulful laments and joyous proclamations of Marvin, Aretha, and Stevie, provided a soundtrack to this blossoming hope. Even the bustling, sometimes challenging, rhythm of the east side block,

with its shouts of children playing hopscotch and the rumble of cars cruising past, felt less daunting now.

The lessons of faith, family, music, and community were shaping him into someone stronger than he ever imagined he could be. Mama and Daddy, with their quiet strength and unwavering belief, had planted those seeds. Mama, her hands always busy with a pot of collard greens or a mending needle, taught me resilience by example. Daddy, with his booming laugh and his stern but loving eyes, showed me the power of a steady presence, of providing, of protecting. Their faith wasn't a show; it was woven into the fabric of their lives, in the way they prayed over meals, in the way they offered help to neighbors, in the way they raised us. They taught us that faith wasn't just about what you said on Sunday, but how you lived every day. Each Sunday brought new songs, new challenges, new moments where the music carried him somewhere he couldn't go alone. It was in the lift of a spiritual, the mournful cry of a gospel hymn, the triumphant shout of a praise song. The music was a vessel, and in it, I could transcend the anxieties of school, the pressures of growing up, the lurking shadows of the streets. It lifted me, weightless, to a place where only joy and spirit resided.

Each rehearsal was a prayer. We'd gather in the church basement, the air thick with the smell of old coffee and dust, but the moment we started to sing, that mundane space transformed. I'd stand before them, my hands cupped, then spread, coaxing out harmony, pushing for power, pulling back for tenderness. "Alright now, y'all," I'd say, my voice still a little shaky, but growing in confidence with each passing week. "Let's take it from the bridge. Remember what Sister Johnson said: 'Sing like you tellin' your testimony.' Let it come from deep down. From that place only God knows." We'd work through the harmonies, sometimes clashing, sometimes soaring. I'd listen intently, picking out a flat note here, a lagging rhythm there. "Michael, give me a little more bottom, son. Let that bass rumble in their souls!" Or, "Denise, that high note is beautiful, but hold it, lean into it, let it vibrate! Don't just sing it, feel it." We didn't just learn notes; we learned to breathe together, to feel the pulse of the song as one body. Each performance was a testimony. A public declaration of faith, not just mine, but ours, the choir's, the community's. When we stood on that choir stand, the lights of the sanctuary warm on our faces, and the organ swelled behind us, the music wasn't just sounds. It was a living, breathing entity, carrying our hopes, our sorrows, our unwavering belief straight to the heavens. I'd watch the faces in the congregation, some with eyes closed, tears streaming, others swaying gently, humming along. In those moments, I knew the power of what we were doing, the profound connection that music forged between us all.

My trombone sat in the corner of his bedroom, still loved, still played on quiet evenings when the house was still. It was a beautiful instrument, brass glinting softly in the dim light, a silent sentinel of my past musical endeavors. I'd take it out sometimes, the cool, familiar metal against my hands, the scent of valve oil a comforting memory. I'd play soft, bluesy melodies, the sound muted by the walls, just for myself. The rich, mellow tones would fill my small room, a private concert, a conversation between me and the instrument, a dialogue of introspection. I'd remember the joy of learning each slide position, the challenge of hitting just the right note, the triumph of a perfectly executed glissando. The trombone had been my first true love, my solitary voice.

But his true instrument now was the choir itself — fifteen voices that he was learning to shape, to blend, to lift. It was a different kind of music, a communal symphony. Leading the choir was like conducting an orchestra of hearts and souls. Each voice was unique, a distinct instrument with its own timbre, its own strengths, its own vulnerabilities. There was Keisha's clear soprano, sometimes a little too eager, needing to be reined in. Jamal's tenor, rich and soulful, but occasionally wandering off-key if he wasn't paying attention. And my own siblings, Denise and Michael, their voices so familiar, so intertwined with my own, yet now part of this larger tapestry. I had to learn to listen not just for the individual notes, but for the collective sound, the way they interwove, creating harmonies that resonated deep within the chest. It was a challenge, a responsibility, but also an immense privilege. When those fifteen voices rose together, a wave of sound, powerful and pure, it was a feeling that dwarfed any satisfaction I'd ever found playing alone. It was the sound of unity, of shared spirit, of hope made audible.

His brother stayed behind the drums. Every Sunday. Every rehearsal. Every performance. Michael was my anchor, my rhythmic partner in crime. His hands, nimble and strong, danced across the drum kit, creating a heartbeat for the choir, a steady pulse that grounded our soaring voices. He didn't just keep time; he felt the music, anticipating every crescendo, every pause, every emotional shift. During rehearsals, I'd turn to him, my eyes silently asking for a louder cymbal crash or a softer snare beat, and he'd respond instantly, without a word, just a slight nod and a subtle shift in his rhythm. The two of them moved in the kind of harmony that can't be taught — the kind that comes from growing up in the same flat, hearing the same prayers, dreaming the same dreams. It was a silent understanding, a shared language that existed beyond words. We'd spent countless hours in our living room, me at Mama's old upright piano, Michael with his practice pads, improvising, exploring, feeling out rhythms. We knew each other's musical instincts, each other's souls. We were two halves of a whole, our individual talents amplified by our undeniable bond. Sometimes, during a particularly moving hymn, I'd catch his eye across the sanctuary, a shared smile passing between us, a mutual acknowledgment of the magic we were creating together. It was a deep, soul-stirring connection, a testament to the power of family, interwoven with the power of music.

As summer slowly faded and middle school approached, Chris felt both excitement and nervousness about the next chapter of his life. The long, languid days of August, filled with the buzzing of cicadas and the distant shouts of kids playing street hockey, were giving way to the crisp, cooler air of September. The scent of fallen leaves and woodsmoke began to mingle with the familiar smell of exhaust fumes and freshly cut grass. School supply lists were taped to refrigerator doors, and the talk amongst my friends shifted from summer adventures to the looming prospect of junior high. I was excited for the newness, the challenge, the chance to prove myself in a larger pond. But a knot of apprehension tightened in my stomach with every passing day.

He knew challenges would come. I'd heard the whispers, the cautionary tales that traveled through the community like wildfire. Stories of older boys, lured by the siren song of quick money, drawn into the dangerous currents of the street. Seen the older boys on corners, their laughter a little too loud, their eyes a little too hard, the tell-tale glint of something forbidden in their hands. They moved with a swagger that spoke of both power and peril, a magnetic pull that I understood, even as I feared it. I'd watched families in the old neighborhood unravel like thread pulled from a sweater, the tight weave of love and loyalty slowly coming undone under the relentless pressure of poverty, addiction, or the cruel allure of the fast life. Their houses, once vibrant with life, slowly darkened, their windows becoming blank, unseeing eyes. I knew the signs, the subtle shifts in demeanor, the gradual erosion of hope.

He knew the streets were patient.¹⁴⁰ They would wait. They were always there, a hungry maw, ready to swallow up those who stumbled, those who faltered, those who felt they had no other choice. The lure of easy money, the false sense of belonging offered by gangs, the numbing escape of drugs – these were the dangers that preyed on young minds, especially those who felt invisible, unheard. I saw it every day, in the shadows of abandoned buildings, in the furtive glances exchanged on street corners, in the hushed conversations of adults. The streets had a language of their own, a harsh, seductive rhythm that could easily drown out the harmonies of home and church.

But he also knew something else — something his parents had planted in him like a seed, something the church had watered, something the music had brought to bloom:

He was not alone. This wasn't just a comforting thought; it was a deep, bone-marrow certainty, a truth that resonated with the very core of my being. It was the feeling of Mama's hand on my forehead when I had a fever, the steady gaze of Daddy when he told me I could do anything if I put my mind to it. It was the collective "Amen" that rose from the congregation, a symphony of shared belief.

He had his family — five siblings, two parents, and a web of aunts, uncles, and cousins who had shown him that love doesn't need a mansion. It just needs a room. Our flat wasn't big, but it was always full. Full of laughter, sometimes arguments, but always, always full of love. Auntie Mae, with her booming laugh and her legendary sweet potato pie, would swing by with a pan still warm from the oven, filling our kitchen with the scent of cinnamon and nutmeg. Uncle Robert, a quiet man who worked at the Ford plant, would fix anything that broke, his calloused hands surprisingly gentle. Cousins, seemingly endless in number, would descend on Sundays after church, transforming our small living room into a riot of noise and energy. We'd play spades until late, the slap of cards against the table, the playful accusations of cheating, the shouts of triumph, all blending into a harmonious chaos. In those moments, nestled in the warmth of their presence, I understood that wealth wasn't measured in square footage or fancy cars, but in the richness of connection, the strength of an embrace, the unwavering loyalty that bound us together. Our flat, though modest, was a palace because it was overflowing with the most precious commodity of all: unconditional love.

He had his church — a building¹⁴⁹ made of brick and wood that somehow contained more warmth than any palace. The sanctuary at True Vine, with its high ceilings and rows of polished pews, felt like a sacred vessel, holding the collective hopes and prayers of generations. The air was always imbued with the lingering scent of lilies from the altar, mixed with the faint, sweet perfume of Sister Bernice's Sunday best and the earthy aroma of old wood. The sunlight, filtered through the stained-glass windows, cast jewel-toned patterns across the floor, painting the space in hues of reverence. A choir stand that felt like a throne, not because of power, but because of purpose. Standing there, leading the junior choir, I felt a deep sense of belonging, a profound connection to something ancient and eternal. It was a place where my voice, and the voices of my young friends, could rise, unhindered, carrying our praise and our yearnings. A community that called his parents "Mom" and "Pop" and meant it. They weren't just titles; they were expressions of genuine affection and respect, a testament to the way my parents had poured into the lives of others, offering guidance, comfort, and a helping hand without question. In turn, all the elders in the church became my "aunties" and "uncles," their watchful eyes and gentle reprimands guiding me, nurturing me, ensuring I knew I was part of a larger, loving family.

He had his faith — small, maybe, ¹⁴³Mustard-seed small. But growing. Always growing. It wasn't a towering, unshakeable mountain yet, but it was a sturdy sapling, its roots reaching deeper with every passing day. It was the quiet certainty that settled in my heart after a particularly moving sermon, when Pastor Jenkins's words about perseverance or grace seemed to speak directly to my soul. Fed by every prayer, whispered in the quiet of my bedroom or shouted in the fervor of Sunday service, I felt it strengthening. Every hymn, sung with passion and conviction, became a nutrient, feeding that nascent belief. Every quiet moment when he felt God's presence the way he felt music — not as something he could see, but as something he could not deny. It was a feeling in my chest, a warmth, a sense of being watched over, guided, cherished. Like the bass line of a gospel song, it wasn't always obvious, but it was always there, supporting everything else, giving structure and meaning to the melody of my life. I couldn't touch God, couldn't see Him, but I could feel Him in the same undeniable way I felt the vibrations of the organ through the soles of my shoes, or the soaring harmonies of the choir resonating in my bones. It was a presence, palpable and real, a constant companion in the symphony of my days.

And he had music — the golden thread that ran through everything, connecting the flat to the church, the trombone to the choir, the block to the blessing. Music was his language. It was how I expressed joy, how I processed sorrow, how I communicated with the divine. When words failed, music spoke. When I felt overwhelmed, music soothed. When I needed strength, music provided it. It was his inheritance, passed down from generations of Black folk who had sung their way through hardship, who had found joy in rhythm, who had woven their pain and their triumphs into melodies that transcended time. It was the spirituals that echoed the cries of the enslaved, the blues that spoke of heartache and resilience, the gospel that proclaimed unwavering hope. This music, this rich tapestry of sound, was my birthright, a sacred trust. It was his calling. I didn't know yet where it would lead me, what form it would ultimately take, but I knew, deep in my soul, that music was not just something I did; it was who I was, an inseparable part of my identity, a divine whisper guiding my path.

With his trombone in one hand and faith in his heart, Chris stepped forward into the future, determined to face whatever came next. I stood at the threshold of middle school, a crossroads where childhood dreams met the looming realities of adulthood, my old brass trombone, worn smooth from years of practice, a tangible link to my past, my individual voice. In my heart, my faith, still tender but resolute, a growing ember that promised warmth and light even in the darkest corners. I looked out my bedroom window at the familiar Detroit street, the rust-colored bricks of the houses across the way, the occasional car cruising by, its bass rattling the windowpane. I knew the world was wide, and not always kind, but I also knew I was equipped, armed with the love of my family, the strength of my community, and the undeniable power of music.

The harmony of his life was still unfolding. New movements waited. New melodies hid around corners he couldn't yet see. The journey was far from over; it was just beginning a new, more complex arrangement. There would be dissonance — he knew that. Notes that clashed, moments when the melody would feel fractured, when the rhythm would falter. Rhythms that broke, periods of uncertainty, of confusion, where the familiar beat of life would skip and stutter. Moments when the music would stop entirely and the silence would feel unbearable, a gaping void where joy and purpose once resided. I understood that life was not a perfectly composed symphony, but a constantly evolving improvisation, full of unexpected turns and challenging intervals.

But he also knew, with the certainty of someone who has stood in the water and risen again, that the song never truly ends. It might pause, it might change tempo, it might introduce a new key, but the melody, the spirit, the underlying truth of it, persists.

It just changes key.

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"End of Volume One"

"The Harmonies of Hope: Vol. II — The Choir Stand"

"Coming 2026"

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About the Author

C.D. Howell was born and raised in Detroit, Michigan. The son of working-class parents who believed in God, music, and the power of family, he grew up in a two-family flat on Detroit's east side before moving to a new neighborhood that changed the trajectory of his life. A lifelong musician, choir director, and man of faith, C.D. writes stories that honor where he came from while pointing toward where grace can take you.

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